



Hindustan Times

PM heads to Uzbekistan, SCO summit; key bilaterals likely

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will on Saturday begin a four-day visit to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan, where he will attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit and hold a bilateral meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin.



PM Narendra Modi leaves on a four-day trip on Saturday.

Modi will visit Uzbekistan from August 29 to 30 at President Shavkat Mirziyoyev's invitation before travelling to Bishkek on August 31 for the SCO Summit.

The meeting with Putin will be among several bilateral engagements Modi will hold on the margins of the summit, the external affairs ministry said on Thursday. Details of other meetings will be announced once they are finalised.

A meeting is scheduled between both the leaders of India and Russia on the sidelines of the summit, secretary (West) Sibi George said at a media briefing, George said the

two leaders were expected to review the entire gamut of the India-Russia relationship.

Earlier this week, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar visited Moscow, where he met Putin and co-chaired the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation meeting.

The SCO Summit, which will mark 25 years of the grouping, is expected to focus on the evolving security scenario in the region, the ministry said. Chi-

continued on →9

India in 'frank' talks with Brics states over meeting declaration

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India is engaged in "frank" conversations with all Brics member states to finalise a consensus declaration at the grouping's summit in New Delhi next month, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday against the backdrop of differences between Iran and UAE over the West Asia conflict.

The ongoing discussions have also focused on resolving the crisis in West Asia through dialogue and diplomacy and ensuring the unimpeded flow of maritime commerce, the people said.

India is set to host the 18th Brics Summit in Delhi during September 12-13, with Chinese Presi-

dent Xi Jinping, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Russian President Vladimir Putin expected to attend the gathering. This will be Xi's first trip to India in seven years and he is expected to hold a bilateral meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The discussions among the Brics states in preparatory meetings have also focused on territorial integrity, protection of civilians and civil infrastructure, the people said.

Iran and the UAE being on opposite sides of the conflict have hit discussions within the Brics grouping. A Brics foreign ministers' meeting in May concluded without a joint statement because of the differences between Iran and the UAE. →P8

2 killed in training plane crash in UP



Wreckage of the four-seater Tecnam P200TC twin-engine aircraft, which crashed in Kanpur on Thursday morning. Bearing registration VT-NBV, the plane was operated by Garg Aviation Ltd, Kanpur. P71

CRASH 20 MINUTES AFTER TAKE OFF

The Tecnam aircraft operated by Garg Aviation took off around 11:30am and crashed about 20 minutes later, killing instructor, Captain Sachin Bhatia, and trainee pilot Abhishek Pujari. →P7

SECOND INCIDENT INVOLVING INSTITUTE

The accident comes two months after another incident involving a VT-NBV operated by Garg Aviation. On June 26, a trainee pilot was injured after being struck by a propeller following a flight. →P7

MAHA GOVT GIVES AUTO-RICKSHAW, TAXI DRIVERS 1 YR TO LEARN MARATHI

Saurabha Kulshreshtha
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnis on Thursday announced a one-year extension for auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers to learn functional Marathi, saying no action would be taken against them during this period. The decision came days after transport minister and Shiv Sena leader Pratap Sarnaik said the licenses of drivers who could not speak Marathi would be suspended in three months.

COPS PROBE 'TOXIC RELATIONSHIP' ANGLE IN TILAK NAGAR MURDER

Jignasa Sinha
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A day after a 21-year-old woman was stabbed to death allegedly stabbed by her boyfriend in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar, police said the investigation has found traces of a "toxic relationship" with harassment, frequent arguments, and accusations of cheating. The suspect, who is on the run, also had a criminal past, they added.

INFANTINO FACES POSSIBLE CRIMINAL COMPLAINT FROM UEFA OVER WC PLAN

MONACO: UEFA is preparing a criminal complaint against FIFA President Gianni Infantino in Swiss courts for possible financial mismanagement over his failed plan to sell future World Cup profits to private investors. UEFA said on Thursday it filed documents in a US court requesting discovery of potential evidence from age-New York investment fund, Joshua Kushner's Thrive Capital Management. →P4

J'KHAND TO MOVE SC AGAINST MINES ACT AMENDMENT

Vishal Kant
letters@hindustantimes.com

RANCHI: The Jharkhand government is set to move the Supreme Court opposing Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, which barred states from levying any tax or cess on mined minerals, people aware of the matter said on Thursday. →P6

ANDHRA: 7 DIE AS BUS RAMS INTO AUTO RICKSHAW

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Seven people were killed and eight, including four children, were seriously injured when a private bus collided with an auto-rickshaw in Palnadu district of Andhra Pradesh early on Thursday, police said. →P7

S Delhi hit by traffic gridlock as multiple projects clog roads

Karn Pratap Singh and Snehl Sinha
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A string of infrastructure and repair projects being carried out simultaneously across the city has brought traffic to a near-standstill on key roads, including the Ring Road and Outer Ring Road, with commuters facing long delays, diversions and shrinking road space.

The impact has been particularly severe in south Delhi, where work on at least six major projects has turned stretches of the Ring Road, Outer Ring Road, Mehrauli-Badarpur Road and Josip Broz Tito Marg into congestion points. The situation is expected to worsen further, with repair work on three major south Delhi flyovers — Nehru Nagar, AIIMS and Barapullah Phase-1 — set to begin simultaneously in a month, as HT reported Thursday.

The Ring Road is among the worst affected. The Public Works Department has started work to extend the Barapullah Elevated Road on the carriageway towards Ashram-Lajpat Nagar, opposite the Sarai Kale Khan Interstate Bus Terminal.

"Merging multi-lane traffic, including vehicles coming from the Sarai Kale Khan flyover, near the same spot where the construction work is underway, is another key factor for the gridlock," a traffic police officer said. The traffic police has been issuing advisories regarding restrictions and diversions.

Experts said construction schedules and manpower deployment could help reduce the duration and extent of disruptions if work is carried out in phases.

{ SERIES AGAINST AUSTRALIA }

After 14 yrs, Dravid, Sehwag back together in India side: Sons of legends part of U-19 squad

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Few surnames in Indian cricket arrive carrying as much baggage as legacy. Sehwag and Dravid are two of them. Now, nearly a generation later, they are back on the same India roster — not as Virat Kohli and Rahul, but as their sons in the Under-19 squad.

On Thursday, Aaryavir Sehwag and Anvay Dravid were named in India's U-19 squad for the three-match, one-day series against Australia, beginning Sep-



Aaryavir Sehwag and Anvay Dravid



tember 18. Neither is in the multi-day squad, but their selection is significant enough to stir memories of an era when their fathers made Australia one of the great stages of Indian cricket's renaissance. The senior Dravid and Sehwag together played for India for

the last time in the Adelaide Test in January 2012.

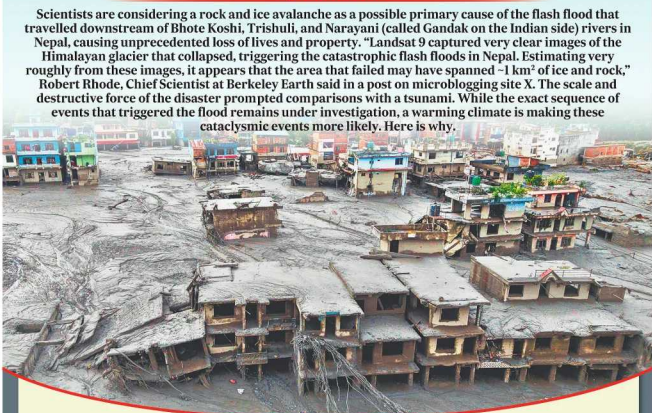
This is the maiden U-19 call-up for Aaryavir. He made his Delhi U-19 debut in the Vinoo Mankad Trophy in 2024, scoring 49 against Manipur. A year later came the innings that really put his name into circulation — 257 for Delhi U-19 against Meghalaya, in the Cooch Behar Trophy.

A wicketkeeper batter, Anvay has captained Karnataka U-19 and accumulated 220 runs in six matches in the Vinoo Mankad Trophy, averaging 55. →P4

NUMBER THEORY

Global warming worsens fury of falling glaciers, floods

By Abhishek Jha



1 Decline in glacier mass appears to be accelerating

While it is not clear what triggered the ice avalanche in the first place, the conditions associated with glacier-related adverse events are the most favourable in recorded history. While historical glacier mass tracking for all glaciers in the world is difficult, the mass of some glaciers monitored annually appears to be in rapid decline, according to the State of the Global Climate report published earlier this year.

Glacier mass balance

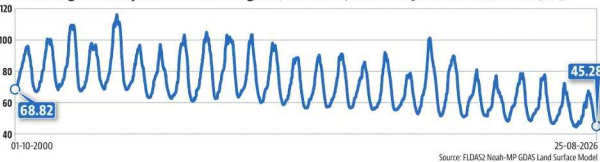


2 Snow pack is declining in the Himalayas

Recent disasters in India in the past few years make an acceleration in glacier melting even more believable. A glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) in Sikkim in October 2023 led to a flood similar to the one seen in Nepal this week. The floods in Uttarakhand in February 2021 were also caused by a rock and ice avalanche like the one in Nepal this week. This is

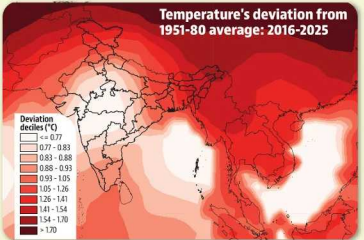
expected when snow pack – ice and glacier formation often happen through compaction or the process of pressing or crushing materials together to make them denser and tightly packed of snow – is declining every year in the Hindu Kush Himalayan (HKH) region, the mountain ranges of the Himalaya, the Hindu Kush, the Karakoram, and the Tibetan plateau.

Area averaged snow pack in the HKH region (Snow water equivalent averaged over 60E-100E, 21N-40N [mm])



3 These trends can only intensify in a warming climate

Declining snow pack and melting glaciers are somewhat self-perpetuating processes in a world where earth's energy balance is out of whack. Ideally, over somewhat long periods of time, earth should send back whatever energy comes in from the sun. But the increasing accumulation of greenhouse gases means that it is keeping some of this energy back on earth, thereby increasing earth's internal energy. Melting snow and ice aids this process because their loss decreases sunlight reflection and darker surfaces absorb more energy, leading to more snow and ice melting. This may be part of the reason why even the air temperature (or what is commonly known as temperature) of the HKH region is increasing faster than of lower latitudes in mainland India.

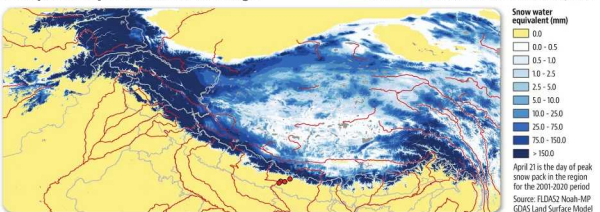


4 The consequences can travel far downstream

Although the Nepal flood originated in the mountains, its consequences put downstream regions, including parts of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, on alert. It will not be surprising if this becomes a regular feature of climate in the future. In other words, the arms of Himalayan floods are made very long by the rivers that originate there and feed the populous Indo-Gangetic

plains below. The region will not be able to support its population without these river systems. To be sure, a warming climate does not just mean more water melting but also more evaporation. Frequent avalanches and GLOFs can trigger big floods, but that does not necessarily imply that rivers will be consistently run deeper and longer in the future.

Snow pack on April 21: 2001-2020 average





Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Rescuers scour Nepal as toll, missing count surge

HT Correspondents
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/CHENNAI/LUCKNOW/DEHRADUN: Rescuers hacked through mountains of mud and debris to pull out stranded survivors and bodies along the Nepal-China border on Thursday, a day after a deadly torrent of water swept several stories high down through six districts in the Himalayan nation following a glacier collapse.

The wave of devastation that inundated villages, swept away buildings and smashed bridges, killed at least 392 people and left another 1,500 missing, including tourists from 31 countries. Indians formed the largest chunk of missing people, with the external affairs ministry saying 290 were unaccounted for in Nepal and another 200 stranded in China.

The force of the monster mudslides and flash floods was such that six bodies were fished out of the Gandak river in Uttar Pradesh's Maharaiganj district—roughly 190 km downstream from the disaster site.

As first responders braved inclement terrain and the deluge—which swept away a 40-km-long border road, a border post, several bridges and scores of settlements up to 100 km downstream—warning came of more impending disasters high up in the Himalayas, where a fragile mountain ecosystem is rapidly imperilled by the climate crisis and melting glaciers.

Nepal National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said a lake had formed roughly 18 kilometers above the Rasuwagadhi checkpoint at the Nepal-China border as the flow there, the Lende River, has been obstructed. "The risk still remains that the natural dam of that lake could burst and cause

continued on >>

morestories

A frantic search by families of NRIs, OCIs >>5
China in emergency mode as premier Li visits Tibet >>2



A rescue personnel with a sniffer dog in the Nuwakot district of Nepal on Thursday



A man sits near a collapsed house in Nuwakot.

MEA: 290 INDIANS UNREACHABLE; 84 RESCUED FROM NEPAL
As many as 290 Indians remain unreachable in flood-hit Nepal, the ministry of external affairs (MEA) said on Thursday. According to MEA's 8 pm update Thursday, 84 Indians were rescued, which included 63 workers of the Trishuli-I project and 21 people from Tamil Nadu. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said India is making "urgent efforts" to ascertain the status and well-being of Indians stuck in flood-hit areas. >>5

Formation of 2 new lakes raise concerns

Jasjeev Gandhi
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A day after the deadly Nepal flash floods, scientists and disaster-response agencies continued to work out the cause, with an ice-rock avalanche still the prime suspect. Meanwhile, a related hazard emerged the same evening as Nepal and China warned of two

lakes that have developed on either side of their border and threaten to burst in the disaster-hit region. Nepal's disaster management authority warned a lake had formed upstream on Lende Khola after debris flow blocked the river's course. Separately, China warned that 3 million cubic metres of water is expected to flow into an already dammed lake on its side of the border. >>5

KHARGE SEEKS ALL-PARTY MEET ON DELIMITATION IN LETTER TO PM

Himanshi Sharma
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking an all-party meeting on delimitation, cautioning the government against any attempt to "bulldoze" the exercise, a day after Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju indicated in an interview that a special Parliament session could be convened.

"...Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs has publicly stated...that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened. This perhaps explains the continued delay in the prorogation of the Monsoon Session itself," Kharge wrote. >>8

HDFC BANK MAY APPEAL ₹6.5-CR REPAYMENT PLAN FOR CHANDRA

Krishna Yadav and Vashi Tiwari
krishna.yadav@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: HDFC Bank plans to challenge the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) decision approving Zee group founder and chairman emeritus Subhash Chandra's ₹6.5 crore repayment plan to resolve his personal insolvency proceedings.

HDFC Bank, which had opposed the plan and voted against it, said it expects to recover only 3.2% of its total claim under the order. The bank is now considering an appeal before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT). >>12

4 Nagas killed, 1 hurt in latest Manipur ambush

Thomas Ngangom
letters@hindustantimes.com

IMPHAL: Four Naga people were killed and a fifth was injured when armed militants ambushed their vehicle in a forested region of Kangpokpi district of Manipur on Thursday morning, deepening the crisis in the northeastern state where violence has raged since 2023.

The militants attacked the vehicle in an isolated area covered by Thabamba Naga villages around 8.30 am in a Naga-dominated region of Kangpokpi, killing four people on the spot, including a school principal, officials said. The strike—the worst in the

ARMED MILITANTS AMBUSHED A VEHICLE IN STATE'S KANGPOKPI DISTRICT; INTENSE FIRING REPORTED AFTER THE ATTACK; ACCUSED YET TO BE IDENTIFIED

state since May 13—hit an already plummeting relationship between the Naga and the Kuki community with the Naga People's Organisation (NPO) announcing a total shutdown in Senapati district with immediate effect.

"I condemned the incident in the strongest terms. I have instructed the security officials to nab and initiate action against the perpetrators of the crime," chief minister Nymam Khemchand Singh said on X.

The killing occurred on the Imphal-Tamenglong (IT) road—a lifeline for the Naga community that dominates Tamenglong and Senapati districts.

The Naga body stated that all shops and business establishments in Senapati district headquarters town will remain shut down indefinitely.

The victims were returning to Senapati after a meeting at Makui village and belonged to

continued on >>

NLS cites 'unavoidable circumstances', cancels this year's convocation

Coovercolly Indresh
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The National Law School of India University (NLSIU) on Thursday cancelled its 34th annual convocation for graduating students, citing "unavoidable circumstances", and said degrees will be conferred to students in absentia.

It comes days after the students and alumni of the institution had said that Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India chairman Manan Kumar Mishra should not be invited to the convocation. The university has not attributed the cancellation to the statement by

NLSIU STUDENTS IN AN EARLIER STATEMENT SAID CJI, BCI CHAIRMAN SHOULD NOT BE INVITED TO EVENT

students. In a letter to graduating students on Thursday, the university registrar said that degrees will be conferred to students in absentia after due approvals by the university's governing bodies. "Students may elect to receive their certificates by courier or collect them at campus," it said. >>17

NADDA HOLDS TALKS WITH GROUP OPPOSING CASTE RESERVATIONS

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union government on Thursday reached out to a group demanding caste-based reservations in education and government jobs be replaced by income-based quotas, a week after the little-known group held a stir at Jantar Mantra.

The government was represented by Union minister J P Nadda. "...Cordial discussions were held. In this connection, we will meet again soon," Nadda said on X. >>6



SENSEX PLUNGES 2.9% IN 'FLASH CRASH' DURING CLOSING AUCTION

MUMBAI: The BSE SENSEX, briefly plunged about 3% during a 20-minute closing auction on Thursday, exacerbating concerns over thin liquidity and manipulation during the window. At one point, the 30-stock index slumped to 74,983.19 points, 2.9% lower than the level of 77,182.91 at 3.45 pm, according to the bourse's data. The gauge recovered nearly all of the losses to eventually close 0.7% lower for the day. >>12

U.P.: SINGER POSTED SONG ON MURDER BEFORE HIS KILLING

LUCKNOW: Hours before he was shot dead near a gym in Shamli district of Uttar Pradesh on Wednesday, Haryana singer and YouTuber Ankur Balyan posted a video of himself singing a line "Murder maar de sadak ke upar (murder on the road)" in his Instagram account, police said on Thursday as investigators piece together the circumstances leading to his murder. >>17

YAMUNA YET TO HIT WARNING LEVEL IN DELHI THIS SEASON

Paras Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com
NEW DELHI: The Yamuna in Delhi has so far failed to reach even its "modest" warning level during this year's monsoon, raising concerns among experts that the river may have missed its annual monsoon flush, which is considered important for its ecological health and for replenishing groundwater in floodplains.

केनरा बैंक
Canara Bank
A Government of India Undertaking

Together We Can

Happy Raksha Bandhan

A THREAD OF LOVE.
A PROMISE OF PROTECTION.
A BOND THAT LASTS FOREVER.

Canara HOME LOAN
7.15% p.a.

Canara VEHICLE LOAN
7.45% p.a.

50% Concession in processing charges

No Documentation charges

No Pre-Payment charges

No Pre-Closure charges

1 Bank Number 1800 1030

www.canarabank.bank.in

SBI
The banker to every Indian

Yono
Power to every Indian

DIGITAL FIRST
CUSTOMER FIRST
NATION ALWAYS

Celebrating the promise of protection with
Captain Y of SBI
Aapka Cyber Rakshak

HAPPY RAKSHA BANDHAN

For assistance, call 1800 1234 | 2100 or visit sbi.bank.in

Follow us on

{ WORLD } 1995 MASSACRE

'Butcher of Bosnia'
Ratko Mladic dead

Ratko Mladic, the former Bosnian Serb military chief dubbed the 'Butcher of Bosnia' for his role in the 1995 Srebrenica massacre, has died, Serbian state-owned RTS reported on Thursday. Mladic, who had suffered several strokes in recent months, was serving a life sentence in The Hague for genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity after overseeing the Srebrenica slaughter, Europe's worst act of bloodshed since World War II. Serbian state officials said Mladic's family had appealed for his release due to his failing health, but those calls were rejected by the Hague tribunal. He was the military face of a brutal trio, led on the political side by ex-Yugoslav president Slobodan Milosevic and former Bosnian Serb leader Radovan Karadzic, as the former Yugoslavia descended into carnage after the fall of communism. The 1995 war left around 100,000 people dead and 2.2 million displaced.

AFP

{ WORLD } CAPTURED IN 2003

9/11 mastermind to
go on trial in June '28

Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the alleged mastermind of the September 11, 2001 attacks on the United States, will go on trial before a US military court in June 2028, an official said Thursday. The long-awaited trial of Mohammed and three other accused 9/11 plotters is scheduled to begin on June 5, 2028 at the US naval base in Guantanamo Bay, Cuba, a court spokesman said. Prosecutors had requested a January 2027 date for the trial of Mohammed, Walid bin Attash, Ali Abdul Aziz Ali and Mustafa Ahmed al-Hawsawi but the presiding military judge said more time was needed to resolve pretrial disputes. Mohammed, also known as 'KSM', was considered one of Al-Qaeda leader Osama bin Laden's top lieutenants before he was captured in March 2003 in Pakistan.

AFP

{ MY INDIA } AGENCY OVERHAUL

Central govt appoints two
NTA directors, joint director

The Centre has appointed two officers as directors and another as joint director in the National Testing Agency (NTA), it undertakes a sweeping overhaul of the country's examination system following the NEET-UG 2026 questions leak. According to separate orders issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) on Thursday, Prasanna Venkatesh V, an IAS officer of the 2012 batch of the Andhra Pradesh cadre, and Ravi Kumar Singh, an IPS officer of the 2012 batch of the AGMUT cadre, have been appointed as directors in the NTA. Both appointments are for five years from the date the officers take charge, or until further orders, whichever is earlier. The DoPT has also selected Amit Samdaria, an IRS officer of the 2016 batch, as joint director (deputy secretary level) in the NTA under the Central Staffing Scheme. His tenure will be four years from the date of taking charge, or until further orders.

HTC

{ BUSINESS } CITES POLICY STABILITY

S&P affirms India's
sovereign rating

Global ratings agency S&P on Thursday affirmed India's sovereign ratings at 'BBB/A-' with a 'Stable' outlook, citing continued policy stability and high infrastructure investment that supports the country's long-term growth prospects. The affirmation comes despite risks from higher energy prices, which could strain India's external balances and inflation outlook given its heavy reliance on imported crude oil. S&P estimates India's real GDP growth to ease slightly to 6.6% this year, a pace it said remains strong compared with most emerging-market peers and a broad global slowdown. But the agency kept the sovereign at the second-lowest investment-grade rung, flagging concerns over weak fiscal performance, heavy debt burden and low GDP per capita.

REUTERS

{ WORLD } JAPANESE ARTIST

'Polka dot queen'
Yayoi Kusama dies

Japanese artist Yayoi Kusama, who splashed her signature polka dots on paintings, sculptures and museum installations around the world, has died, her studio said Thursday. She was 97. Kusama died August 24 at a hospital in Tokyo, Yayoi Kusama Studio said, without specifying the cause of death. "She continued to paint until her final days, never setting aside her brush, and continued exploration of forever love and eternal soul," her studio said. One of Japan's most respected contemporary artists, Kusama was widely exhibited around the world, including the Museum of Modern Art, the Whitney Museum of American Art in New York and the Museum Ludwig in Germany. Repetitive motifs were her trademark, in various shapes, resembling netting, swirls or worms, but most often dots. "Polka dots are fabulous," Kusama said in a 2012 interview with the Associated Press. "I will keep painting until I die."

AP

Hivital

THE PULSE OF FRONTIER SCIENCE,
FOR YOUR HEALTH AND WELLNESS.

New drugs reshaping the cholesterol control battle

Binayak Dasgupta
and Rhythma Kaul

The cholesterol threat and how the new heart drugs work

Cardiovascular disease kills around 3.2 million Indians a year — one in four deaths, and nearly half of all deaths between 40 and 69. Behind a large share sits a single cause, silent and treatable: LDL cholesterol, sticking to the walls of arteries and hardening into plaque that narrows the passage feeding the heart. High LDL is one of the biggest modifiable causes of that toll, and for most people who have it, it is an untreated or treated with the same medicine that has been prescribed for three decades.

For as long as high cholesterol has been treatable, it has been treated the same way: a daily statin, taken for life.

Statins work by blocking an enzyme the liver uses to make cholesterol, with less being made, the liver pulls more LDL out of the blood. They are cheap, generic in India, and over thirty years they have been shown to do the thing that matters: reduce heart attacks, strokes and cardiovascular death. But they have a ceiling — even the strongest doses of LDL, by 35 to 40 per cent, and for some patients that is not enough.

The last decade has opened a second front. Cardiology has learned to target a protein made in the liver called PCSK9, which destroys the receptors the liver uses to pull LDL from the bloodstream. Block PCSK9 and the receptors survive longer, clear more LDL, and cholesterol falls sharply. Four drugs now do this, in different ways.

Two are antibodies — evolucumab and alirocumab — injected under the skin every fortnight. They bind to PCSK9 and neutralise it, cutting LDL by another 50 to 60 per cent on top of a statin. Both are available in India at significantly higher cost than statins, and large trials have shown they prevent heart attacks and strokes in high-risk patients, not just lower the number.

A third injection, inclisiran, uses small interfering RNA to stop PCSK9 production. It was the first PCSK9 drug in the first place. Two shots a year cut LDL by around 50 per cent. Its cardiovascular outcomes trial reads out through the end of this year and next.

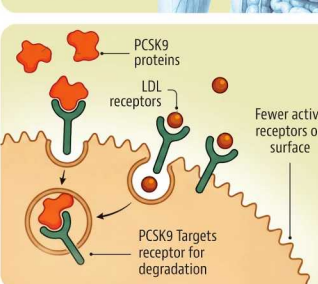
The fourth is the newcomer: enclitide, a once-daily tablet cleared by the US Food and Drug Administration in July 2026. Earlier PCSK9 drugs needed needles because proteins do not survive the stomach; enclitide is built with macrocyclic peptide chemistry — the peptide folded into a ring that reaches the bloodstream intact. Its main trial cut LDL by 56 per cent against placebo. The outcomes trial is still running. In India, inclisiran has cleared a Phase 3 trial.

Beyond the four drugs sits a different class again. Two experimental gene therapies, both in early human trials, do not give the body a drug that wears off. They change the DNA inside liver cells in a single infusion. VERVE-102 edits the PCSK9 gene for the patient whose cholesterol stays dangerously high on the maxi-

Liver, key to heart health

The liver produces one of the enzymes that makes cholesterol, which is needed to build cell walls.

But too much cholesterol is harmful too. So the liver acts as the regulator. When there is excess cholesterol, the liver pulls in LDL through receptors on its surface. The retrieved LDL is either reused or disposed of in bile.



Statins

Statins block the enzyme that makes cholesterol, so the liver pulls more LDL out of the bloodstream. It is the standard for managing cholesterol, available cheaply.

But it does not attack PCSK9, a protein that hinders liver's ability to retrieve LDL.

PCSK9 inhibitors

These bind to PCSK9, a protein that interferes with the liver's ability to retrieve LDL — neutralising it, so the liver keeps clearing cholesterol from the blood.

The new solutions: 3 injections, 1 tablet

Evolucumab, alirocumab deliver antibodies that bind to PCSK9, taken once every two weeks. Inclisiran stops PCSK9 from being made in the first place, injected twice a year. Enclitide, the first oral PCSK9 inhibitor. Its functioning is similar to the antibody injections.

Beyond drugs: gene editing

Two experimental therapies in early human trials use a single infusion to edit DNA inside liver cells — switching off genes involved in cholesterol production permanently. No further treatment needed. Both have shown sharp LDL reductions in small trials of patients with genetic forms of very high cholesterol. Phase 2 trials begin in 2026.

ANGPTL3, a different gene involved in fat regulation. Early results show LDL reductions of around 50 to 60 per cent that hold for at least 18 months. Both trials are small and confined to patients with rare genetic conditions. Phase 2 trials begin this year.

For now, clinicians say, the newer therapies are for the patient whose cholesterol stays dangerously high on the maxi-

mum statin they can tolerate, for the small number who cannot take statins at all, and for people born with familial hypercholesterolemia, whose levels are perilous from birth. What "dangerously high" means is not a single number; for someone who has already had a heart attack or stroke, the target is under 50; for a young person who has already had an event, under 35, sometimes 30.

Vital explains the science and conversations at the frontier of health and wellness. It isn't medical advice — what to do with it is a conversation for you and your doctor.



Access HT Vital online for the full story and more

New lakes add to flood concerns amid hunt for avalanche trigger

Jasveer Gandhok
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A day after the deadly Nepal flash floods, scientists and disaster-response agencies continue to work out what had caused the wall of water, mud and debris that tore through the Himalayan river valleys along the China-Nepal border on August 26. The working hypothesis remains an ice-rock avalanche — a large chunk of a glacier breaking away and cascading down — but what set that avalanche off is still under examination.

The single sharpest development on Thursday came from the US Geological Survey (USGS), which revised its initial reading of the event. What it had first logged as a magnitude 4.4 earthquake — briefly assessed to be the trigger — was reclassified as a magnitude 5.2 landslide. "Additional analysis of nearby seismic stations, long period seismic waves, and satellite imagery led to the determination that the seismic event was instead a glacial collapse and debris flow, and that no earthquake had occurred," the USGS said. In other words, the event that had officials in Kathmandu had first suspected of triggering the flood was the collapse itself.

Second, related, hazard emerged the same evening as Nepal and China warned of two lakes that have developed on either side of their border and threaten to burst in a region still grappling with the catastrophic flood. Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority warned that a lake had formed upstream on the Lhunde Khola after the debris flow blocked the river's course. "A lake covering an area of approximately 0.11 square kilometres has formed due to the obstruction of the Lhunde Khola's flow in the upstream area, about 18 kilometres above the Basuwasgathi border point," the authority said on X. "Given the risk of a potential major flood, all individuals in the downstream areas are urged to exercise necessary vigilance and remain on high alert." The con-



An area covered in mud and silt in Nepal's Nuwakot on Thursday. PH

cern is a familiar one in the region: an ice-and-debris dam of this kind is inherently unstable, and its sudden failure can send a second surge through the same valley that has just been devastated.

Separately, China warned that 3 million cubic meters of water — the equivalent of about 1,200 Olympic swimming pools — are expected to flow into an already dammed lake on its side of the border over the next three days, creating a high risk of a breach, with peak flow expected around September 1. "The volume of water is continuing to increase, and so is the risk," Zhu Jinpeng, a researcher at the water resources ministry's hydrology department, told state broadcaster CCTV.

Experts have long flagged this pattern of vulnerability across the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH). An assessment published in May by the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) found that four of the eight countries in the HKH region — India, Nepal, Bangladesh and Pakistan — each recorded more than 10 major disasters in 2025, ranging from landslides and floods to glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs). In June, ICIMOD's monsoon outlook cautioned that a below-normal monsoon forecast for parts of the HKH in 2026 would not translate into lower disaster risk, short bursts of intense rainfall.

rising temperatures and growing water stress could, it warned, make the season more dangerous rather than less.

The underlying science has also been sharpening. In a peer-reviewed study published only weeks before the disaster in the journal *Global and Planetary Change*, a team led by Gunjan Silwal of Newcastle University — including a co-author from ICIMOD — mapped glacier change in the Langtang catchment, the Nepal basin immediately south of where the August 26 collapse originated. It found that glacierised areas above 4,000 metres in the catchment had been warming at 0.31°C per decade — roughly five times the global average — and that the region had lost more than 40% of the ice cover mapped at the end of the Little Ice Age. Most significantly for events of the kind now under investigation, the paper identified fragmentation and disconnection of high-elevation ice — the same process suspected in the Basuwasgathi — as the emerging dominant mode of glacier retreat in the region, with what its authors described as implications for "associated geohazards."

The same corridor has now flooded twice in 14 months. In July 2025, a flash flood attributed to a GLOF struck the Lhunde Khola — the same tributary that has now been obstructed a second time. "The

Lhunde Khola has flooded twice in fourteen months, this time most probably triggered by an ice avalanche blocking the river and releasing a sudden surge downstream. This still needs to be confirmed, as we receive further information. These are cascading hazards: a cryosphere event becomes a flood in a settlement within hours," said Saswata Sanyal, disaster risk reduction specialist at ICIMOD in Nepal.

Some Indian regions have had similar incidents. On August 13, at least seven workers were killed at an under-construction hydropower tunnel in Chamoli, more than 24 hours after a suspected aquifer burst sent a surge of water and debris rushing down the Vishnugad-Pipalkoti project site. In February 2021, the same district was hit by a massive rock and ice avalanche that triggered a flash flood down the Rishi Ganga and Dhauliganga rivers, killing more than 200 people and damaging two hydropower projects.

Himanshu Thakkar, coordinator of the South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers and People (SANDRP), said the sites of these disasters "in this case, the lessons were not being drawn. 'We are not revisiting our disasters. We need learnings to come out and more importantly, independent committees to do a full audit into these incidents,' he said.

Neera Shrestha Pradhan, water and disaster risk reduction lead at ICIMOD, said the immediate need was for community-based early warning systems that could operate across borders. "In this case, the cross-border early warning system could be a strong example of cooperation between the two countries. Our experience shows that providing information alone is not enough. Communities also need to be aware about how to translate this information and prepare themselves to act on it without panicking. This event is a hard reminder that in areas where such disasters are more likely, communities need to stay alert and stay prepared for the unforeseen," she said.

China in emergency mode as premier Li visits mudslide-hit Tibet; many missing

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com

President Xi Jinping dispatched his second-in-command to visit areas of Tibet devastated by a flash flood, underscoring the seriousness of China's response to the disaster that killed hundreds of people.

Premier Li Qiang inspected emergency rescue and relief operations on Thursday afternoon, visiting with first responders and people displaced into temporary shelters, according to the official Xinhua News Agency. Xi has called for sparing no effort in searching for those missing, as well as relocating and resettling any residents at risk.

China deployed over 500 personnel from the armed forces, four helicopters, multiple drones and a V-20 transport aircraft to assist in the operations, Xinhua said.



Workers repair a damaged road leading to Gyirong Port, Tibet. REUTERS

The Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Natural Resources allocated 120 million yuan (\$17.9 million) in central natural disaster relief funds to support Tibet, with another 100 million yuan in central budget investment earmarked to aid post-disaster emergency recovery and reconstruction efforts.

The scale of the response and the arrival of a senior leader mere hours after the catastrophe suggest Beijing is pulling out all stops to cope with the disaster that threatens to choke off the majority of overland trade between China and Nepal. Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian told reporters in Beijing on Thursday that about 100 Chinese nationals are missing in

Nepal, based on the information received from local authorities. On China's side, three were confirmed dead.

China is maintaining close communication with Nepal and coordinating search and rescue efforts in the affected area, Lin said.

Security camera video from Gyirong Port in Tibet, some 100 kilometres away from Kathmandu, was then obscured by the mud and water.

CCTV reported that the edge of the debris flow reached about 2.5 kilometres downstream from Gyirong Port, with mud deposits up to 1.5 metres thick. A barrier lake has formed in the region, complicating rescue operations. China's Ministry of Water Resources said it's monitoring the water volume of the barrier lake. It warned that the risks are rising that it could burst in the next three days, leading to more secondary damage.

NIISIU cancels convocation, to give degrees in absentia

Cooverally Indresh
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The National Law School of India University (NIISIU) on Thursday cancelled its 34th annual convocation for graduating students, citing "unavoidable circumstances", and said degrees will be conferred to students in absentia.

It comes days after the students and alumni of the institution had said that Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India chairman Manan Kumar Mishra should not be invited to the convocation event.

The university has not attributed the cancellation to the statement by students.

In a letter to graduating students on Thursday, the university registrar said that degrees will be conferred to students in absentia after due approvals by the university's governing bodies.

"Despite our collective best efforts, due to unavoidable circumstances, we are unable to hold the 34th annual convocation," the letter said. "Students may elect to receive their certificates by courier or collect them at campus."

Details of the process will be communicated through a separate form, the communication added.

THE UNIVERSITY REGISTRAR SAID DEGREES WILL BE CONFERRED TO STUDENTS IN ABSENTIA AFTER DUE APPROVALS BY THE GOVERNING BODIES OF VARSITY

The cancellation comes days after a section of students and alumni of NIISIU raised objection to the proposed participation of the CJI and the BCI chairman in the September 12 event. A statement opposing their participation was endorsed by 165 graduating students of the class of 2026, 409 current students and 128 alumni.

The opposition from a section of the NIISIU student fraternity came in the backdrop of a dispute involving NALSAR University of Law and the BCI. Amid a campaign by students and faculty of the Hyderabad-based university concerning the proposed participation of CJI Surya Kant in an event on campus, the BCI on August 13 expressed disapproval over the cancellation of the convocation, describing it "a once-in-a-lifetime milestone" for students.

"Graduating students were eagerly looking forward to celebrating the occasion with their parents and family members after years of academic hard work. The cancellation has taken away an important opportunity for students and their families to mark the significant achievement together," she added.

Bengaluru-based NIISIU's students and alumni criticised the BCI's intervention and sought its unconditional apology to the NALSAR students and faculty.

"We are aware that the BCI has closed all proceedings against NALSAR. However, the fact that such unconstitutional and illegal proceedings can be initiated by a statutory body against students and faculty members of a public university in the first place does not alter the nature or the larger impact of such actions or dilute the responsibility of the Chairman and the NIISIU students and alumni said in a statement dated August 15.

HT's phone calls seeking a comment from the NIISIU vice-chancellor went unanswered. NIISIU alumna Moumami Das expressed disappointment over the cancellation of the convocation, describing it "a once-in-a-lifetime milestone" for students.

"Graduating students were eagerly looking forward to celebrating the occasion with their parents and family members after years of academic hard work. The cancellation has taken away an important opportunity for students and their families to mark the significant achievement together," she added.

Nahed Ataula
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi will be Bengaluru to take part in a gig workers' conference, a follow-up to the interaction he had with them during the Karnataka Assembly elections in 2023, chief minister DK Shivakumar said (CHECK).

After meeting Gandhi in New Delhi on Thursday, the chief minister said a date for Gandhi's visit is yet to be fixed. The conference will deliberate on the Karnataka Platform-based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act, which seeks to protect workers' rights, constitute a welfare fund for them and mandates delivery partners to pay welfare fees ranging from 1% to 5% of payouts.

The gig workers welfare legislation was conceived by Gandhi during his interaction with them when he campaigned in Bengaluru during the Assembly polls in May 2023. Over a dosa with the gig workers at a restaurant,

Gandhi discussed their lives, asking about difficulties with rising prices and lack of employment stability.

Shivakumar said the gig workers' legislation was formulated on Gandhi's suggestions. The Congress leader was expected to take up the gig workers' cause at the national level, Shivakumar added.

Based on the meeting of his counterparts at the recently held Congress Working Committee to restructure the education policy, Shivakumar said his government constituted a cabinet sub-committee. The government issued an order on Thursday constituting the cabinet sub-committee headed by health minister UT Khader. The five-member panel has been asked to look into the challenges faced by students and submit a report within a month.

The panel's brief includes preventing question paper leaks and malpractice, ensuring transparency, fairness and accountability in state examinations and recruitment processes; and



DK Shivakumar

establishing a fixed and time bound examination and recruitment calendar.

Besides strengthening the infrastructure and improving quality of education in government schools, the emphasis will also be on pre-university colleges and universities, including addressing teacher vacancies and ensuring adequate laboratories, libraries, hostels and other essential facilities. It will also focus on strengthening counselling and student support systems, addressing academic and examination-related stress and developing measures for suicide

prevention in coaching hubs, hostels and residential educational institutions.

"The cabinet sub-committee shall undertake wider consultations with stakeholders i.e. students, parents, teachers, institutions and others across the state on the above aspects. The cabinet sub-committee can opt for subject-experts from respective fields to assist them in this exercise. The committee shall submit the report within one month," the order said.

Cong top brass to decide on min's resignation

Shivakumar said a decision regarding planning and statistics minister B Nagendra's resignation will be taken by the Congress high command. "Why are the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Janata Dal (Secular-JDS) targeting Nagendra when not a single rupee has been seized from the minister regarding the ₹89 crore misappropriation in the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation (KMSTDC)?"

asked. An indication that Nagendra might be asked to step down was imminent with Shivakumar saying Nagendra is a disciplined soldier of the party. "For the party's sake, he is ready to sacrifice anything," he added.

Defending the minister, Shivakumar said there's no case against him. "It's an issue without an issue. No signature has been found and there is no order. They are unnecessarily creating issues," he maintained. Leader of opposition in the Legislative Assembly R Ashoka told the media that he was 100% confident of Nagendra stepping down in the light of the pressure from the opposition parties. He questioned why the present government reinducted Nagendra, when he was dropped by former chief minister Siddaramaiah after the embezzlement allegations surfaced. "We have not taken Gowda's name as many times as we took Nagendra's demanding his resignation on the floor of the House. If Nagendra is not dropped the opposition will continue the agitation, Ashoka said.

Clash erupts during Eid Milad procession in Bengaluru, 8 held

Cooverally Indresh
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Eight people, including two minors, have been arrested following a clash between two groups during an Eid Milad procession in Basavanagudi, police said on Thursday, adding that three separate cases in connection with the Basavanagudi police registered cases based on complaints from both sides as well as a complaint related to obstruction of public roads and traffic. Police said the situation was brought under control and additional security arrangements have been made in the area. In the first case, police registered a case related to alleged acts affecting communal harmony based on a complaint filed by Abhaz Razaq. Hindu activists Puneeth Kerehalli, Gopigowda and Vinod Naik were arrested in connection with the case.

The second case was registered based on a complaint filed by Hindu activist Puneeth Kerehalli. Police booked Aakmal Pasha, Abubakar and Syed under charges including attempt to murder and provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. They were subsequently arrested. Two minors allegedly involved in the incident were taken into custody and produced before the juvenile Justice Board, police said.

A third case was registered

THE POLICE FILED CASES BASED ON COMPLAINTS FROM BOTH SIDES AS WELL AS A COMPLAINT ON OBSTRUCTION OF PUBLIC ROADS AND TRAFFIC

by Basavanagudi police on the alleged obstruction of a public road and disruption of traffic. According to police, the incident occurred on Wednesday afternoon when an Eid Milad procession was moving from Banashankari towards KR Road in Basavanagudi. Participants were carrying religious flags and raising slogans.

Another group, including members of the Rashtra Bahadri, Gopigowda and Vinod Naik were arrested in connection with the case.

As the situation escalated, a person identified as Marul was allegedly assaulted. Police used lathis to disperse the groups. Police said the investigation into the three cases is underway. He said a Hindu youth was allegedly assaulted and sustained injuries during the confrontation. Police have stepped up security arrangements in the area to prevent further incidents.

PREGNANT B'LRU COP ATTACKED WITH IRON ROD AT RLY STATION: COPS

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 28-year-old pregnant constable was allegedly attacked with an iron rod at the Bengaluru city railway police station by a man upset over a delay in registering his complaint about a stolen mobile phone, police said on Thursday.

The incident occurred at around 5.10 am on August 26 when the accused entered the police station and told constable Shilpa D that his mobile phone, which he had left for charging on platform number 1A, had been stolen, they said. According to the FIR, Shilpa said she asked him to wait for the station officer for some time. The accused later returned to the station and finding the constable alone, confronted her in Hindi, asking why she had not taken his complaint allegedly threatened to kill her.

He then picked up an iron rod attached to a heavy barricade wheel and allegedly struck her on the head six or seven times before fleeing, the FIR said. Shilpa raised an alarm, following which the station officer and another woman constable came to her aid. Shilpa is out of danger, police said.

Shilpa's brother Krishna Naik said his sister was two months pregnant at the time of the incident. He urged senior police officers to take immediate action.

Reviewing the case, identified as Ganjandra, has since been arrested, they added.

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Karnataka government is exploring pilot projects using ElevenLabs' voice AI cloning technology for investment promotion, healthcare, culture and citizen services, officials said on Thursday.

The discussions were held between home, information technology, biotechnology and e-Governance minister Priyank Kharge, a team from voice AI company ElevenLabs and senior officials of the department, they said.

According to a statement from the minister's office, the engagement is part of Karnataka's broader effort to work with leading technology companies and translate advances in AI into effective, efficient and accessible services for citizens.

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Karnataka government is undertaking road improvement works covering 2,500 km across Bengaluru at an estimated cost of ₹8,000 crore, Minister Krishna Byre Gowda said on Thursday.

Gowda directed officials to expedite the works, ensure quality and closely monitor their execution, while ordering an immediate survey and repair of potholes on the city's arterial and sub-arterial roads.

Reviewing the development works and civic programmes being implemented across the

five municipal corporations under the Greater Bengaluru Authority at the Council Hall, he said the city has to move to move from reacting to civic problems to addressing the systems that cause them. "Dysfunction has become the norm of the city. We have to change that," the Greater Bengaluru development minister said in a statement. He emphasised that officials and the government should work together as one team. Road improvement works covering approximately 2,500 km are being taken up at a drive since July 15 in coordination with various government departments, including white-topping projects, Gowda

said. He directed officials to expedite the ongoing works, maintain strict quality standards and conduct continuous field-level monitoring.

Gowda also directed officials to conduct a comprehensive survey of potholes on all arterial and sub-arterial roads and repair them on priority. He said Bengaluru has approximately 840 km of stormwater drains (rajkulaves) within the GBA limits, of which around 640 km have already been developed.

The remaining 200 km will be developed at an estimated cost of ₹2,000 crore. The minister said he would hold a monthly meeting to monitor progress.

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

KALABURGI: Amid speculation about the possibility of a minor change in D K Shivakumar-led cabinet in Karnataka, AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday said that the matter has not come to him till now.

He said any such matters, whether to induct or remove someone from the ministry, must ultimately come before him. "I'm not aware of it, if you are aware please tell me. No such matter has come to me till now," Kharge told reporters here in response to a question on speculation about minor changes in the cabinet.

Asked about CM Shivakumar's move to Delhi to discuss the matter with party leadership, he said, "I'm in Gulbarga (Kalaburagi). If anything, the file will have to come to me. It won't go



Mallikarjun Kharge

to anyone else. If anyone is to be appointed, inducted as minister or removed, it cannot go ahead without coming to me. Once it comes I will let you know," Shivakumar was in New Delhi on Thursday and met the Congress leadership, including Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi.

Speculation is rife that Shivakumar discussed minor Cabinet changes with the high command, proposing to replace a couple of incumbents to accommodate disgruntled lawmakers

who are not dialling down their demand for ministerial berths.

With no women represented in his Cabinet, pressure is mounting on him to fill one vacant berth with a woman minister. He is also said to have discussed the reported offer by Minister B Nagendra to step down, amid Opposition BJP and JDS intensifying their agitation demanding his removal from the Cabinet, over charges related to the alleged embezzlement of crores of rupees at a state-run ST Development corporation.

Speaking to reporters in Delhi, Shivakumar said he met Rahul Gandhi and discussed instructions regarding his removal on national interest, and party interest. To a question on Nagendra's resignation, he reiterated that the former is a loyal Congress worker and is ready for any sacrifice for the party.

State launches GIS app to geo-tag rural water assets, curb fake bills: Minister

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka Minister Eshwar B Khandre on Thursday said a GIS-based mobile and web application had been launched to manage rural water assets and curb fake bills.

Launching the applications developed for the management of the rural water supply infrastructure, Khandre said all rural water assets would be geo-tagged to ensure greater transparency. "There are more than three lakh water assets in the state and all of them will be digitised by the end of September. So far, documentation of more than 70,000 water assets has been completed as part of the first phase of verification," the Rural Development and Panchayat Raj minister said.

Khandre said the system would have a three-tier verification mechanism. At the first stage, assistant engineers, junior engineers and support engineers would physically inspect all water assets.



Eshwar Khandre

At the second stage, assistant executive engineers would conduct random inspections of five per cent of the assets. If any irregularity is detected, the concerned contractors and engineers would be held accountable.

At the third stage, executive engineers would carry out random inspections of two per cent of the assets. The three-tier verification system would increase accountability among contractors and officials implementing drinking water and sanitation projects and bring greater transparency, Khandre said.

and Sanitation Department developed the application in collaboration with the Karnataka State Remote Sensing Applications Centre, he said.

The application will enable geo-tagging of all works and water assets with an accuracy of five metres. This will help prevent bills that have not been executed and facilitate assessment of the quality of assets created under various schemes, Khandre said.

Basic information of all works and water asset, including its physical condition and operational and maintenance status, will be recorded on the application to help ensure more effective implementation of government schemes at the grassroots level, he said. Khandre said the department had made it mandatory to create and maintain records of tanks, open wells, pump houses, water treatment plants, balancing reservoirs, lakes, laboratories and hand pumps created under rural drinking water and sanitation programmes.

He directed officials to first conduct a detailed audit of existing drinking water assets in rural areas, followed by new and ongoing works.

Geo-tagging borewells would help third-party verification of details such as the depth to which they were drilled, the depth at which pipes were installed and the horsepower of the motors fitted, helping curb corruption, the minister said.

The department's objective was to make rural drinking water schemes more people-friendly by ensuring transparency. Training had been provided to officials concerned on the new application, he said.

Khandre directed the chief executive officers of zilla panchayats, who attended the programme online, to remove pump sets and electricity connections from defunct borewells to prevent unnecessary electricity bills. He said instructions had been issued to recharge dried-up borewells under the VB-G RAM G programme.

Clean your own vacant plots, min urges owners

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Greater Bengaluru minister Krishna Byre Gowda on Thursday urged vacant-plot owners to clean their properties themselves to avoid higher charges from the civic body.

He was speaking after symbolically launching the civic body's drive to clean vacant plots in the city. He urged owners to clean their plots themselves, the minister said. The remaining 70 per cent have not yet undertaken the cleaning. The civic body will therefore begin clearing these plots from Thursday, with the cost recovered from the respective property owners through property tax, he said.

"It will cost you less if you clean your plot yourself than if the civic body does it. Keep your property clean and contribute to improving Bengaluru," he said. Many vacant plots have extensive overgrowth and require heavy equipment for cleaning, with at least three hours needed to complete the work.



Krishna Byre Gowda

30 per cent of owners cleaned their plots themselves, the minister said. The remaining 70 per cent have not yet undertaken the cleaning. The civic body will therefore begin clearing these plots from Thursday, with the cost recovered from the respective property owners through property tax, he said. "It will cost you less if you clean your plot yourself than if the civic body does it. Keep your property clean and contribute to improving Bengaluru," he said. Many vacant plots have extensive overgrowth and require heavy equipment for cleaning, with at least three hours needed to complete the work.

Damaged houses at a residential area in Trishuli in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday.



13 from K'taka stuck in Nepal, Tibet after flash floods: CMO

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: At least 13 people from Karnataka, 11 of them from Bengaluru Urban district, are stranded in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region, chief minister D K Shivakumar's office said on Thursday.

The state government has stepped up efforts to rescue its residents stranded in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region following flash floods in Nepal that killed several people and left many others stranded.

According to a statement issued by the CMO, the State Emergency Operations Centre had, as of Thursday evening, compiled details of 13 Karnataka residents stranded in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region. The state's residents are part of groups that also comprise people from other states. "Of these, 11 are from Bengaluru Urban district, one from Dharwad district and one from Shimoga district. Most of the stranded persons are located in Trime, Rasuwa district, Nepal, while a few are in Darchen, Tibet Autonomous Region," the statement said. The SEOC and the Office of the Resident Commissioner, Karnataka Bhavan, New Delhi, are regularly sharing details of those stranded with the Rapid Response Cells of the

ministry of external affairs and Indian missions in Kathmandu and Beijing, it said.

The details have been shared with the Integrated Control Room of the Ministry of Home Affairs to facilitate assistance, evacuation and the safe return of Karnataka residents, the statement said.

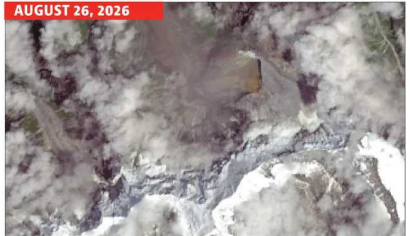
The state government urged those stranded, their relatives and tour operators to provide the required details through a Google form to help coordinate rescue and evacuation efforts with the authorities concerned. It advised Karnataka residents in the affected areas to remain in safe locations and follow instructions and advisories issued by local authorities and Indian missions. They were advised against travelling through affected routes unless authorised by competent authorities.

The statement said chief minister D K Shivakumar and Deputy C P Parameshwara were closely monitoring the situation and were in constant touch with the MEA and the Resident Commissioner, Karnataka Bhavan, New Delhi, regarding the safety and welfare of Karnataka residents. Earlier in the day, Parameshwara had said five people from Bengaluru who had travelled to Nepal were missing and efforts were on to contact them.

SPOTLIGHT | NEPAL FLOODS



392
TOTAL DEATHS
290
INDIANS
MISSING



A structure (left) in Nepal's Nuwakot district ravaged by the flash flood on Wednesday; and satellite images (right, top and bottom) of the glacier in Langtang before and after it collapsed on Wednesday morning, setting off flash floods and seismic waves equivalent to a 5.2 magnitude earthquake, according to the US Geological Survey. PTI REUTERS

From TN to WB, appeals for contact

5 Vijay Karthik, Joydeep Thakur, Maulik Pathak and Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI/KOLKATA/ AHMEDABAD/HYDERABAD/MUMBAI: As many as 290 Indians remain unreachable in Nepal on Thursday, the ministry of external affairs (MEA) said on Thursday. According to the MEA's latest update, issued at 8 pm on Thursday, 84 Indians were rescued, which included 63 workers of the Trishuli-I project and 21 people from Tamil Nadu who had travelled to Nepal for the Kailash-Anasarovar Yatra.

TAMIL NADU
86 remain missing
As many as 83 pilgrims, mostly women, from Tamil Nadu, and three from Puducherry remained unreachable in Nepal on Thursday, Tamil Nadu minister A Rajamohan said.

In an announcement made in the state assembly, Rajamohan said overall 106 pilgrims, including three from Puducherry, had gone to Nepal under the Kailash-Anasarovar Yatra in multiple groups. "Currently, 86 of them could not be traced due to the flash floods in Nepal," he said. Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay conducted a review meeting to oversee the relief measures, the government said.

WEST BENGAL

32 tourists missing
A group of 32 pilgrims, including from West Bengal who had gone for the Kailash-Anasarovar Yatra remained missing, said Dibyajyoti Basu, founder of Cholo Jai, the travel agency in Kolkata through which the tourists had gone to Nepal. "There were 30 tourists and two of our staff," said Basu.

Sharmistha Bhownik Roy, daughter-in-law of former Union minister Mukul Roy and 61-year-old Subhash Chandra Ghosh, a Venkatesh, a resident of Sydney, are among the missing people. Sharmistha's husband, Subhash, former TMC MLA from



(Top) Search operations underway in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Thursday following the deadly flash flood. (Bottom) A second tranche of HADR material dispatched for Nepal in the IAF's C-17 aircraft from the Hindon Airfield in Ghaziabad on Thursday.

Bijpur in North 24 Parganas, told HT. "When we last spoke, she was at Kerung. She mostly spoke with the children. They were supposed to enter Tibet on Wednesday. After seeing the terrifying visuals of the flood washing away the immigration office at Kerung, I have been trying to call her. Her phone is switched off and there is no news of her. We are all very tensed."

Subhojit Sen, Ghosh's childhood friend told HT. "He went alone with the team; his wife and two daughters didn't go. He last updated his status from Rasuwa around 6.14 am on Wednesday. But thereafter there is no update from him. His phone is switched off."

CM Suvendu Adhikari told reporters on Thursday. "We are in touch with the Indian embassy in Kathmandu. We are preparing for their [missing people's] safe return."

GUJARAT

17 uncontrollable
At least 17 people, including 14 foreign nationals, who travelled from Gujarat are either missing or uncontrollable, a State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC) official aware of the development said on Thursday.

A person who was initially reported missing has since been confirmed safe, officials said. Among those missing is an NRI couple from Anand. Bimalkumar Patel, 46, and his wife Jaiminiben Patel, who were last contacted on Wednesday. Bimalkumar's brother told media persons that the couple had left their 12-year-old son with him in Anand. "The 12-year-old son doesn't know what happened to his parents," he said.



At least seven people from Andhra Pradesh have so far been identified as missing or stranded in Nepal-China borders, according to the information collected by state authorities on Thursday. State information technology minister Nara Lokesh and his department officials are closely monitoring the safety of pilgrims stranded along the Nepal-China border through Real Time Governance Society (RTGS).

7 tourists missing
At least seven people from Andhra Pradesh have so far been identified as missing or stranded in Nepal-China borders, according to the information collected by state authorities on Thursday. State information technology minister Nara Lokesh and his department officials are closely monitoring the safety of pilgrims stranded along the Nepal-China border through Real Time Governance Society (RTGS).

MAHARASHTRA

106 leave for home
As many as 106 tourists from Nagpur who were stranded in flood-hit Nepal have safely left Kathmandu for Danapur in Bihar following Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnis's intervention, his office said on Thursday evening.

Earlier, the State Disaster Management Department had said that at least 114 people from Maharashtra were stuck in the Himalayan nation, and 53 of them were confirmed missing. Fadnis called Nepal MP Sandeep Rana, who arranged four mini-buses to transport 106 per-

sons from Kathmandu to Janakpur, the CMO said, adding that they were expected to reach the Janakpur-Bihar border on Friday morning.

ODISHA

2 NRIs among 3 missing

An Australia-based couple from Odisha's Khordha district holidaying in Nepal, and a 20-year-old, remain missing, state officials said. Siddharth Kumar Sahu and Sandeep Mohapatra had been living in Australia since 2018, travelled to Nepal on August 22 for sightseeing. Kallam Nigam, 20, from Baripada town of Mayurbhanj district, is the third Odia reported missing.

Prithvi Panda, the nodal officer from Odisha who is coordinating with Ministry of External Affairs said the government is in touch with Mohapatra's family. "Sandeep last spoke to his brother, Sarabha Mohapatra over the phone on August 25. 'We are in touch with their family and are trying to collect information and forward it to the Indian Embassy in Nepal,' Panda said.

CHHATTISGARH

One woman missing
A woman from Raipur has gone missing in Nepal following the floods in the country, prompting the Chhattisgarh government to coordinate with central agencies and local authorities to trace her, a government press release said on Thursday.

The state government, acting on the instructions of CM Vishnu Deo Sai, is collecting information on Chhattisgarh residents who travelled to or are currently in Nepal, the release said. Close to 33 people from Kerala are missing, the MEA said. Meanwhile, around 14 people from various districts of Uttar Pradesh have contacted the state's helpline to locate their family members till Thursday.

(With inputs from Agencies, Ritesh Mishra and Debrajita Mohanty)

Floods sever way back home for Kailash pilgrims

Subhash Pathak
letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: Near the sacred shores of Lake Mansarovar in Tibet, a group of 55 Indian pilgrims is in a state of anxious limbo. Their spiritual journey to Mount Kailash, said to be the abode of Lord Shiva, continues for now, but the path home has been severed by nature's fury. A day before catastrophic flash floods tore through the Nepal-China border region on August 26 these devotees completed visa formalities at the Gyirong County immigration office and pressed onward. Today, with the Friendship Bridge between Nepal and China washed away and roads obliterated, they plea their hopes on authorities to restore a lifeline by their scheduled return on September 3.

Mohan Jee Chaubey, 59, a resident of Ahirvillu village in Buxar, Bihar, counts himself among the fortunate. Alongside Mandavi Singh, 61, from Gaya, he was part of the contingent that spent the entirety of August 25, clearing Chinese visa procedures and other formalities at the Gyirong immigration office. The batch of the pilgrims reached Lake Mansarovar on Thursday in the afternoon, said Chaubey.

The day after the group departed for the high-altitude pilgrimage from the border port, disaster struck. The immigration office itself was completely washed away by the raging waters of the Bhotekoshi river (known as the Lhunde on the Tibetan side), Chaubey and his companions had already moved beyond the danger line, escaping the devastation that claimed scores of lives and left hundreds missing across the borders.

"We are safe for now, and the agency has arranged food, cooking materials and coats," Chaubey said from near Man-



Mohan Jee Chaubey, 59, from Bihar, who was in Tibet since August 25.

sarovar Lake, roughly 600 kilometres from the Gyirong border point. He is travelling under a package organised by Jodhpur-based Travel Pocket. The full contingent numbers 71, including support staff from the agency. Among the pilgrims are two from Jharkhand, one of them Tulshi Dutta from Dhanbad.

The pilgrims now find themselves cut off from the most practical exit route. They are scheduled to re-enter Gyirong County and proceed to Kathmandu on September 3. Until then, they remain deep in Tibet, hoping that bilateral efforts will succeed in restoring the vital communication and transport links in time. "We only wish that China and Nepal will be able to restore the connection," said Tulshi Dutta. "We believe the Chinese authorities will certainly arrange another way if needed."

Mount Kailash is a Himalayan peak in southwestern Tibet, near China's borders with Nepal and India. It rises more than 6,400 metres (21,000 feet) above sea level and lies close to Lake Mansarovar. Both have long been part of Sanskrit religious and literary traditions.

Several NRIs, OCIs missing: Frantic calls by families hit cellphone connectivity hurdle

Prawesh Lama
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Viswanath Venkatesh is making frantic calls to find out about his brother, Sreedharan Iyer, his wife Lakshmi, and their children, Rudra and Rishabh—all Australian citizens and part of a 13-member group missing in Nepal after Wednesday's devastating flash floods.

Among the hundreds missing in the Nepal flash floods are a number of Non-Resident Indians and Overseas Citizens of India. "All 13 including my brother's family were in Rasuwa. They were accompanied by their close friends who are also NRIs and OCIs," said Venkatesh, a resident of Sydney. "They were supposed to cross the Nepal border yesterday (Wednesday) after having breakfast at the hotel in Rasuwa, Nepal. The tour operators said they are also unable to get any information about the whereabouts of the whole group."

With cellphone connectivity down in Rasuwa district, the hot spot of flash floods, and no road, connectivity due to washed-away



The 13-member group from Australia missing in Nepal.

bridges, family members of those touring the Himalayan nation are unsure whether their loved ones are stranded in the hills, or have taken shelter, or the worst, did not survive the floods.

Among those missing are tourists from 30 countries, mostly from India, US, UK, Australia, Ukraine, Malaysia, Canada and Singapore. The ministry of external affairs has said at least 290 Indian citizens are "not contactable" yet. Most tourists were in Rasuwa for the Kailash-Anasarovar

Yatra, via Tibet, or two treks: Langtang trek and Gosai Kunda. Asthiva Agarwal, whose brother-in-law Himanshu, a Canadian citizen, is also missing, said most families are unsure if the hotel where pilgrims were lodged in Rasuwa is still intact. "My sister last spoke to her husband on Tuesday night. Once we heard of the incident on Wednesday, we tried calling Himanshu but to no avail. We have seen photos of the hotel where they were staying but unsure if it is still there. I am making arrangements to fly to Nepal and join the search ops," Agni said.

The Himalayan Glacier Adventure and Travel Company, one of the tour operators to Kailash-Anasarovar, is assisting the families. "Eight of our staff are also missing. We are unable to reach our local contacts in Rasuwa. The roads are also blocked and phone connectivity is down. We have compiled photos of 46 who are still missing," said tour organiser Neupane said. Vikram Kuvallala, a Mumbai resident, said his sister, Shital Chetan Chaulan, a US national, is also missing. "When we spoke to her last, she was having her breakfast at the Kailash Hotel in Rasuwa. We do not know if anything has happened to her at the hotel or while travelling to the border."

Brigadier General Rajaram Basnet, Nepal Army spokesperson, said over 4,200 army personnel are engaged in the search and rescue operations. "Work is on to restore road communication and phone networks in Rasuwa. The priority is to find all those missing. This also includes our 44 army personnel."

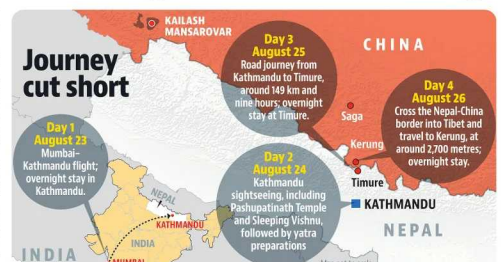
5 Mum docs among 61 trekkers missing

HT Correspondents
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Five doctors from Mumbai, including family physician Dr Milind P Chitaley and his pathologist wife Megha, are among 61 Indian travellers reported missing after a flood hit the Tibet side of the customs and immigration point in Nepal.

Dr Chitaley, 64, who is also the co-founder of the trekking agency Hills & Trails, was leading the group. Among the missing are Dr Anand Deshpande, who heads the blood bank of Hinduja Hospital, and his wife Dr Gayatri Deshpande, head of the department of gynaecology and obstetrics at Nanavati Hospital.

A senior officer from Hinduja Hospital said, "We are in touch with their daughter who is in Bengaluru, but is yet to get any information about her parents." A spokesperson from Nanavati Hospital said, "We have reached out to the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu and received a list of rescued people, in which Dr Ganesh's name does figure. Offi-



cers from Max Hospitals (which manages Nanavati hospital) in Kathmandu are also trying to look for details." Dr Meenakshi Ramani, the dentist of Anita Sawant, wife of former health minister Dr Deepak Sawant, and her relatives are also missing. Dr Meenakshi's husband, Dr Sanjay, said, "I have made several calls to helpline numbers

over the last few hours. I do not know how to get in touch with my wife and the others missing or get any information about their safety," said Ramani. Kalyan-based Swarnand Sunil Sudarshan Subhedar is also part of Chitaley's group. An anxious Swarnand told HT that he has lost all contact with his father since Wednesday evening. "His phone

is unreachable. I have been trying to contact the authorities for an update since last night but I still haven't been able to locate my father," he said. Dr Chitaley has decades of experience trekking in the Himalayas, and was selected as the climbing doctor for the First Indian Civilian Expedition to Kanchenjunga, an 8,000-metre peak, in 1988.

Guidelines issued to set up special SDRF units

Neeraj Chauhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Centre has issued detailed guidelines to states and union territories for raising, equipping, operationalising and training within the next five years, state disaster response forces (SDRFs), with preference to be given to Agniveers and NCC certificate holders for direct recruitment and 15% of the openings reserved for women.

The units will be modelled on the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) to deal with the natural and man-made disasters. The amended disaster management act, 2025, cleared by the Parliament last year, mandates every state and UT to have a specialised SDRF to deal with the disasters.

The latest guidelines, issued by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) in June this year, but made public earlier this week, provide a comprehensive uniform framework aimed at creating decentralised disaster response capacity.

The units will work seamlessly with the NDRF and SDRFs of neighbouring states and the officials familiar with the matter said.

While many states have established SDRFs in some form, their capacities and training standards vary.

In some states, they exist largely on paper and disaster response functions fall on NDRF. Asserting that a capable SDRF provides immediate, local specialised response, ensuring

THE CENTRE ISSUED THE GUIDELINES FOR A UNIFIED FRAMEWORK TO CREATE DECENTRALISED DISASTER RESPONSE CAPACITY

timely life-saving operations while NDRF can focus on L-3 events (catastrophic, large scale) and advanced capabilities, training and mentoring, the guidelines state that "over-reliance on NDRF even for minor hazards weakens national specialised capacity and can delay state-level response due to connectivity and competing demands during widespread events".

On the structure and strength of SDRFs, the guidelines say that "they shall be organised on the battalion model - 600 to 1200 personnel in each battalion, broadly aligned with NDRF", and headed by a director general of police (DGP) rank officer.

Each battalion can be divided into 9 to 10 multi-disciplinary, self-sufficient teams and each team will have "45-50 responders with all integral rescue, medical, communications and logistics elements".

Asserting that SDRFs should recruit "young", "fit" personnel not above the age of 50 as responders, the NDMA guidelines say that for direct recruitment, "Agniveers and NCC certificate holders would be given preference". The primary source

of hiring responders would be state armed police, state police, central armed police forces (CAPFs), armed forces, ex-servicemen (especially engineers) and ex-NDRF personnel.

Each SDRF, the guidelines add, "should include engineers, technicians, medical staff, communications experts, dog handlers, divers and CBRN (chemical, biological, radiological and nuclear) specialists".

The deployment of SDRFs, according to the guidelines, should be based on "predominant terrain and hazard characteristics".

For instance, "teams may be sub-divided to cover multiple valleys, pilgrimage corridors or landslide-prone sectors," the guidelines said, adding that emphasis should be on seasonal and anticipatory positioning during monsoon, winter and peak pilgrimage periods.

The guidelines also provide a provision for SDRFs to conduct safety preventive audits as part of their non-disaster mandate.

In this, they will conduct safety audits at high-footfall recreational, tourist and religious congregation sites, "with particular emphasis on locations associated with water-based recreation (rivers, reservoirs, waterfalls, ghats, beaches, dams and water parks) and mass religious gatherings (melas, yatras, pilgrimage circuits, festival venues)".

At no point, NDMA has said, should SDRFs be deployed "in situations requiring the use of armed force or enforcement of law and order".

Vishal Kant
letters@hindustantimes.com

RANCHI: The Jharkhand government is set to move the Supreme Court opposing the amendments to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, which barred States from levying any tax or cess on mined minerals in their respective territorial jurisdictions, people aware of the development said on Thursday.

During the monsoon session, both houses of Parliament passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation)

Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to curb taxation of minerals by state governments. This prompted Opposition from some of the non-BJP ruled states including the mine-rich Jharkhand, which has warned of a "massive agitation" besides challenging the move legally.

"Chief minister Hemant Soren, who also holds the mines portfolio, has given his nod to move the apex court over the issue. The law department is currently vetting the proposal. After a long

legal battle, a historic judgement by a Constitution Bench of the apex court had given states rights over mineral wealth. We will go back to the Supreme Court soon," a senior official aware of the development said.

The amendments to the act stem from a July 2024 ruling by the Supreme Court that upheld the power of states to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands. The verdict was hailed as a major fiscal victory for mineral-rich states such as Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and

Rajasthan, potentially yielding a revenue windfall, but it deeply unsettled mining companies facing retrospective taxation.

A week after the Supreme Court ruling, the Jharkhand assembly passed a bill providing for varying degrees of tax on different minerals mined in the state on a per-metric-tonne basis.

The act was further amended in the 2025 budget session to increase the cess on mined minerals in the state by up to four times. Officials said the state government projected revenue of ₹14,656 crore from the Min-

eral Bearing Land Cess in the 2026-27 budget and earmarked these funds for welfare schemes. Up in arms against the amendments, the ruling allies, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) and Congress, have announced phased agitations at the grassroots level, transforming the issue into a major political one in the state, describing it as an attack on "Jharkhandi Asmita" and a transgression into the rights of the Adivasis and the Moohais (original inhabitants) who suffer land loss, displacement, and pollution from mining.

Nadda meets group opposing caste quota

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union government on Thursday reached out to a group demanding caste-based reservations in education and government jobs to be replaced by income-based quotas, a week after the little-known group held a stir in Jantar Mantar that was attended by the group's members Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan and Mrityunjay Pathak.

The government was represented by Union minister JP Nadda, who earlier held negotiations with Cockroach Janata Party leaders whose protest against paper leaks in July eventually resulted in the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Nadda posted on X referring to the meeting with the group that gathered for protest at Jantar Mantar on August 21. However, he did not mention the demands put forth by the group nor did he elaborate on what transpired at the meeting.

Following the movement that took place at Jantar Mantar on 21 August, cordial discussions were held, as per the pre-determined schedule, with Shri Harsh Dubey, Shri Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan, and Shri Mrityunjay Pathak, members of the team. In this connection, we will meet again soon," he wrote.

The government had not indicated earlier that a meeting with



JP Nadda

the group had been scheduled.

A senior BJP leader said the government is keen to prevent the repetition of the CJP protest that stretched on for over 30 days. The standoff between the CJP and the government escalated after police used force against the group as it tried to march to Parliament on July 20.

"The government has already announced that it is engaging with students. Meeting with this group is part of the outreach planned to hear their concerns and address those... as Nadda ji himself said there will be a follow up meeting," said the BJP leader quoted above.

Dubey said the interaction was positive.

"The Positive Initiative for the Welfare of All Society... Today, our team met with the honorable Shri J. P. Nadda Ji. During this time, there was a brief discussion with him regarding the demonstration that took place on August 21. This meeting is an important step towards dialogue. We will soon meet again with the honorable Nadda ji and strive to move forward with a positive and just decision in the interest of all society," he said.

PUNJAB CM MANN SNUBS UNIONS AS STIR HALTS WORK ACROSS DEPTHS

CHANDIGARH: Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday refused to meet the protesting employees' unions, hours before he was scheduled to meet them, even as a statewide strike brought work across government departments to a grinding halt, causing widespread inconvenience to people.

"Employees are an important part of our family and we are ready to listen to every legitimate concern of theirs... But dialogue and strikes cannot proceed together," Mann posted on X before the scheduled meet at the Punjab Armed Police headquarters in Jalandhar at 1 pm.

While the government said it would take action against absentee employees, the protesters struck a defiant note, saying they will decide on the next course of action on Sunday and announced they would burn effigies of the CM on Friday and Saturday.

The state-wide "mahila hartal," organised by the Punjab Sanjha Mulazam Manch, an umbrella coalition representing over 150 employee unions, saw nearly 400,000 staff members proceed on mass casual leave. They were joined by roughly 350,000 pensioners demonstrating outside district headquarters and government offices, demanding the release of the pending 18% dearness allowance (DA), the implementation of the Old Pension Scheme (OPS) and regularisation of contractual employees. **HTC**

Congress slams NCLT over Chandra ruling

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A National Company Law Tribunal ruling that sharply reduced Essel Group chairman Subhash Chandra's liability in a personal insolvency case has sparked a political row, with the Congress saying that a settlement of just ₹6.5 crore against lenders' claims of more than ₹22,000 crore raises questions about the fairness of the process.

In a post on X, Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi called NCLT as "Neta-Company Loot Tribunal" and party general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala said such reductions in debt value, called haircuts in financial parlance, amount to a loan waiver for industrialists. Neither leader, nor Congress' communications chief Jairam Ramesh, who also raised the issue, named Chandra but referenced the NCLT decision.

A statement from Chandra's office said that he has not borrowed from any lender in the matter and was only a personal guarantor for loans to companies "remotely connected" to the Essel Group. The total claims against him in the personal insolvency proceedings is only ₹3,992 crore and not ₹22,000 crore, the statement said. It also said a claim of ₹620 crore was settled and borrower entities have offered to pay ₹1,063 crore. If a farmer doesn't pay 50



Subhash Chandra

thousand, his hand gets auctioned off. If a salaried person misses even one EMI, bank goons show up at the house. Poor students can't even get loans for education. But for select "friends," bank money is like personal property - withdraw as much as you want, repay whatever you feel like. The Modi government has created two systems in the country - one for a handful of billionaires, and another for everyone else," Gandhi said in his post.

"The tragedy of this country is that in name of haircuts, people are being pickpocketed. For pickpocketing, they devised a beautiful word called haircut. In name of haircut through NCLT this is an institutional loot and plunder of public and bank money by Modi government. These are words of late Prime Minister Manmohan Singh," Surjewala said at a press conference.

Ramesh claimed that haircut has become "mundan" (hair shaving). "This is not just a haircut. It is actually a mudan and makes a complete mockery of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016," he said on X.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.

HT brunch
RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE

EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



2 KILLED AS KARNI SENA FRACTIONS CLASH IN UJJAIN

Shruti Tomar

letters@hindustantimes.com

BHOPAL: Two people, including a 42-year-old Karni Sena district vice-president, were killed and several others injured in a clash between two factions of the group at an eatery (dhaba) in Madhya Pradesh's Ujjain in the early hours of Wednesday, police said.

Police identified the deceased as district vice-president Rahul Darbar alias Vijay Pratap and eatery owner Jitendra Pawar, 35.

"The incident began as a verbal altercation between Karni Sena member Shakti Singh and Darbar over appointment to the official post. Shakti slapped Rahul during a gathering at the dhaba, prompting Rahul to retaliate. Shakti then called his friend Sonu Banjara, who arrived with more than a dozen armed men," Chhimanganj police station in-charge Vivek Kanodia said.

The attackers, wielding knives and swords, assaulted Rahul. He died at the hospital and the body of dhaba owner, Jitendra Pawar, was found later. An FIR was registered against five people, including Shakti Singh and Sonu Banjara.

2ND RAJ VARSITY STUDENT DIES BY SUICIDE IN 2 DAYS

JAIPUR: A 21-year-old student was found dead in a private hotel near a university in Rajasthan's Jaipur, marking the second such suspected suicide case associated with the institution in two days, police said on Thursday.

Police said the body of the second-year Cardiac Perfusion Technology (CPT) student from Uttar Pradesh's Mathura was recovered from his hostel room late Wednesday after other students alerted Chandwaji police.

Chandwaji SHO Rajbir Singh said, "A foul smell was emanating from the body. We suspect that the student may have died by suicide one or two days ago."

The case was reported a day after a 19-year-old B.Tech student from Lucknow allegedly died by suicide on campus.

HELP US JUST A CALL AWAY
SNEHR: 011-65978187
SUNITA: 011-46018404
9315767849

Kanpur training plane crash kills 2

Neha LM Tripathi
and Haidar Nargvi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/KANPUR: A flight instructor and a trainee pilot were killed after a training aircraft crashed near Kanpur on Thursday, officials said. The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has launched an investigation into the accident.

The Tecnam P2006T twin-engine aircraft, registered as VT-NV and operated by Garg Aviation Ltd, crashed while on a training flight in the local flying area of Kanpur Civil Airport, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) said. The aircraft was about five nautical miles from Kanpur Civil Airport, near the Ganga Barrage, when the accident occurred, according to preliminary information shared by the regulator. It was returning to the airport when it crashed, local officials said.



The wreckage of the plane near the Ganga Barrage in Kanpur.

"There were two persons on board, a trainee pilot and an instructor. Both sustained fatal injuries in the accident," the DGCA said. The circumstances and cause of the accident will be determined through the investigation, it added.

It was not clear who was at the controls. A three-member DGCA team has left for the site for regulatory oversight and coordination, while the AAIB will carry out the accident investigation in accordance with the applicable rules, the regulator said.

latter said.

DGCA officials are yet to confirm if the aircraft underwent maintenance recently.

The two victims were identified as instructor Captain Sachin Bhatia, a resident of Gujarat, and trainee pilot Abhishek Pujari of Karnataka. Kanpur commissioner of police Raghubir Lal said, Lal said the aircraft took off at around 11.30am and crashed about 20 minutes later while returning to the airport. It came down in a field belonging to Sarvesh Kumar near Nathupurva, he said. Captain Bhatia was an experienced instructor with around 3,000 hours of flying experience, Lal added.

The four-seater aircraft was wrecked in the crash, with debris scattered across the site. Police cordoned off the area and began recovery operations. Local officials also pointed to

poor weather conditions in the area around the time of the crash.

Garg Aviation chairman Vijay Garg said Bhatia was an experienced, examiner-level instructor. "We are all shocked and dismayed by how this happened and how the aircraft crashed," he said, adding that a DGCA team had reached the site and begun its inquiry.

The aircraft had been brought to Kanpur for training operations in 2023, according to police. Garg Aviation has operated a flying training facility in Kanpur for nearly 31 years.

The accident comes two months after another incident involving a VT-NV operated by Garg Aviation. On June 26, a trainee pilot was injured after being struck by a propeller following a night instructional flight. The DGCA subsequently de-registered the instructor and grounded the aircraft involved in that incident.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWITW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Baliyan posted song on murder hours before he was killed, say cops

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

LUCKNOW: Hours before he was shot dead near a gym in Shamli district of Uttar Pradesh on Wednesday, Haryana singer and YouTuber Ankit Baliyan posted a video of himself singing a line "Murder maar de sadak ke upar (murder on the road)" on his Instagram account, police said on Thursday as investigators piece together the circumstances leading to his murder.

"Investigators are trying to establish whether the post was merely a coincidence or linked to the singer's killing," an investigator who spoke on condition of anonymity said.

Baliyan was shot dead around 7pm on Wednesday. CCTV footage showed around four assailants arriving on two motorcycles and firing approximately 18 rounds. One bullet hit Baliyan in the head, killing him on the spot, additional director general (law and order) Amitabh Yash said on Thursday.

Soon after the murder, a social-media post surfaced claiming that the Gogi gang was behind the attack and named Bholu Shahpuria as the alleged perpetrator. Police said they are verifying the authenticity of the social media account and the claim.

"Immediately following the



Ankit Baliyan

incident, a social media post surfaced claiming that the Gogi gang was responsible for the attack and identified an individual named Bholu Shahpuria as the perpetrator. The authenticity of the social media post is currently being verified," Yash said.

The probe has been expanded to Shamli, Baghpat and Muzaffarnagar, with four police teams being sent to Haryana to trace the suspected shooters, the investigator said. The Special Task Force (STF) is assisting the district police in analysing technical and intelligence inputs, he said.

Baliyan's post-mortem examination was conducted late Wednesday night under videography and his body was handed over to his family on Thursday morning. Around 30 policemen have been deployed outside his residence in Banti Khara village in Shamli.

NLSIU cancels convocation, degrees to be given in absentia

Coovercolly Indresh

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The National Law School of India University (NLSIU) on Thursday cancelled its 34th annual convocation for graduating students, citing "unavoidable circumstances", and said degrees will be conferred to students in absentia.

It comes days after the students and alumni of the institution had said that Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India chairman Manan Kumar Mishra should not be invited to the convocation event. The university has not attributed the cancellation to the statement by students.

In a letter to graduating students on Thursday, the university registrar said that degrees will be conferred to students in absentia after due approvals by the university's governing bodies. "Despite our collective best efforts, due to unavoidable circumstances, we are unable to hold the 34th annual convocation," the letter said. "Students may elect to receive their certificates by courier or collect them at campus."

Details of the process will be communicated through a separate form, the communication added. The cancellation comes days after a section of students and alumni of NLSIU raised objections to the proposed participation of the CJI and the BCI chairman in the September 12 event. A statement opposing their participation was endorsed by 165 graduating students of the class of 2026, 409 current students and 128 alumni. The opposition from a section of the NLSIU student fraternity came in the backdrop of a dispute involving NALSAR University of Law and the BCI. Amid a campaign by students and faculty of the Hyderabad-based university concerning the proposed participation of CJI Surya Kant in an event on campus, the BCI on August 13 temporarily stopped enrolment for NALSAR's graduating batch, only to reverse the deci-

THE MOVE COMES IN THE BACKDROP OF STUDENTS OPPOSING AN INVITE TO CJI AND BCI CHIEF MANAN KUMAR MISHRA

sion within hours.

Bengaluru-based NLSIU's students and alumni criticised the BCI's intervention and sought its unconditional apology to the NALSAR students and faculty.

"We are aware that the BCI has closed all proceedings against NALSAR. However, the fact that such unconstitutional and illegal proceedings can be initiated by a statutory body against students and faculty members of a public university in the first place does not alter the nature or the larger impact of such actions or dilute the responsibility of the Chairman and the BCI," NLSIU students and alumni said in a statement dated August 15.

HT's phone call seeking a comment from the NLSIU vice-chancellor went unanswered. NLSIU alumna Moumami Das expressed disappointment over the cancellation of the convocation, describing it "a once-in-a-lifetime milestone" for students.

"Graduating students were eagerly looking forward to celebrating the occasion. The cancellation has taken away an important opportunity for students and their families to mark the significant achievement together," she added.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



READ EVERY SUNDAY



India, Canada can bring more certainty to global growth: FM

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: India and Canada formally launched their inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue in Toronto on Thursday as finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that in a time of global uncertainties, the two countries could work together to bring predictability to global growth.

The Dialogue took place between Sitharaman and her Canadian counterpart François-Philippe Champagne, who pitched his country as a stable and reliable partner for India in a period of disruption.

Canada is going through tariff turmoil amid a trade war with its southern neighbour, the United States. And Prime Minister Mark Carney has focused on diversifying Canada's trade basket to mitigate the risk of economic shocks. In his opening remarks at the Dialogue commenced, Champagne said, "Canada has been saying we're going to be strong at home and diversified abroad. So this is very much our diversification agenda in action." He said the two countries have "unique" complementarity. "That is really the key message today. We can be a very strategic partner to India when it comes to energy security, to food security. We



Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaks during a meeting with her Canadian counterpart François-Philippe Champagne and other officials in Toronto on Thursday.

had the privilege of hosting the minister yesterday for dinner," the Canadian finance minister stressed. In return, he said later, India can provide to Canada "scale, talent and technology". After the meeting, he said it was "very fruitful" and the two countries were "aligned." "Canada is a very stable and predictable partner. And I think in today's world, what people are looking for is most trust. And I think trust is what India can offer to our Indian colleagues and Indian friends. And I hope so today that this is just the beginning," Champagne noted, touting his country as the partner of choice for energy and food security for India, particularly in the current crisis in the Strait of Hormuz.

Sitharaman agreed. She said this was possibly the "best time to start this dialogue" between Canada and India "because global uncertainties being what they are and they seem to continue with severity. Economies like Canada and India can bring so much more predictability and certainty to the global growth."

She elaborated after concluding the discussion, stating, "The world is going through a profound transformation, there's just a lot of uncertainty everywhere and the geopolitical and economic realities are constantly evolving. So in this background, closer economic cooperation has become increasingly important to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive econo-

mies both in Canada and in India."

She added the Dialogue reflected the "broad ambition" to move beyond traditional trade and goods and services and "build a deeper economic partnership encompassing investment, finance, capital markets, and regulatory cooperation."

She also said that on food security, energy security and also on critical minerals, a relationship can be built between the two countries "that will go to the strengthening of our people's purchasing power, ability to face supply chain disruptions, and it will be a conscious effort to address the concentration risks in global sourcing of commodities or intermediary products."

She alluded to her multiple meetings with Canadian pension funds' leaders on Wednesday, along with sovereign wealth funds, private entrepreneurs and the private equity leadership. Canadian pension funds have nearly CAD 110 billion invested in India.

Both countries are also expected to pursue a foreign investment protection agreement, with the objective of completing the negotiations at the same time as the ongoing comprehensive economic partnership agreement talks end.

NATIONAL INTEREST SUPREME: PREZ MURMU'S MANTRA TO IFS TRAINEES

NEW DELHI: India's engagement with the world should always align closely with the aspirations of our people, President Droupadi Murmu said on Thursday, while addressing trainee officers of Indian Foreign Service (IFS). She advised the diplomats to remain alert to emerging opportunities as "India's economic rise is creating new possibilities for our engagement with the world".

Speaking at an event of 2025 batch IFS officers and two diplomats from Bhutan, President Murmu said, "India's engagement with the world should always align closely with the aspirations of our people: Rashtrahit Sarvopari (national interest is supreme). This should remain an enduring principle of Indian Foreign Service officers' professional lives." She also highlighted the expanding role of diplomacy as the country progresses towards the goal of becoming Viskit Bharat by 2047.

Reminding the officers of their "privilege and responsibility of representing India abroad and advancing the nation's interests, and strengthening India's relations with countries across the world",

M u r m u pointed out that India's economic rise is creating new possibilities for our engagement with the world.

India building consensus over Brics declaration at New Delhi

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India is engaged in "frank" conversations with all Brics member states to finalise a consensus declaration at the grouping's summit in New Delhi next month, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday against the backdrop of differences between Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) over the West Asia conflict.

The ongoing discussions have also focused on resolving the crisis in West Asia through dialogue and diplomacy and ensuring the unimpeded flow of maritime commerce, the people said.

India is set to host the 18th Brics Summit on September 12-13 with Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Russian President Vladimir Putin expected to attend. This will be Xi's first trip to India in seven years and he is expected to hold a bilateral meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

A BRICS FOREIGN MINISTERS' MEETING IN MAY CONCLUDED WITHOUT A JOINT STATEMENT BECAUSE OF THE DIFFERENCES BETWEEN IRAN AND THE UAE

The discussions among the Brics states in preparatory meetings have focused on territorial integrity, free flow of maritime commerce, protection of civilians and civil infrastructure, and resolving the West Asia conflict through dialogue and diplomacy, the people said.

Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has resulted in severe energy supply disruptions. Iran and the UAE being on opposite sides of the conflict have hit discussions within the Brics

grouping. A Brics foreign ministers' meeting in May concluded without a joint statement because of the differences between Iran and the UAE. Indian officials said earlier that the chair's statement and outcome document issued by India after the foreign ministers' meeting, which featured two specific paragraphs on which unanimity couldn't be reached, could serve as the template for the declaration.

India is engaged in "candid" discussions with Brics states to forge consensus on all important matters, the people said when responding to a question on whether the upcoming summit will produce a joint declaration.

The external affairs ministry said in a statement that India's leadership of Brics chairship is guided by the theme of "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability", reflecting the vision of a people-centric approach rooted in the spirit of "humanity first".

Kharage seeks all-party meet on delimitation

Himanshi Sharma
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking an all-party meeting on delimitation, cautioning the government against any attempt to "bulldoze" the exercise, a day after Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju indicated in an interview that a special Parliament session could be convened.

"I am writing now to reiterate this request since the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs has publicly stated in a television interview last night that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened. This per-

haps explains the continued delay in the prorogation of the Monsoon Session itself," Kharge wrote in the letter.

Kharge, who also holds charge as the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, said he first raised the matter on July 16, when he asked the prime minister to convene an all-party meeting on the government's delimitation proposals and give parties adequate time to examine them before any special session is called. The Monsoon Session, which typically concludes by late August, has not yet been formally prorogued this year, a delay

directly to the government's deliberations on a special session. There was no immediate response from the government or the BJP to Kharge's letter.

POLICE ACTION AT ABHISHEK'S OFFICE TRIGGERS CHAOS

KOLKATA: Chaos prevailed at Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee's office on Camac Street in Kolkata on Thursday afternoon when civic body officials accompanied by a police contingent entered the premises to remove a billboard that the TMC had allegedly installed without permission.

Banerjee and some TMC leaders blocked the path of the police and KMC officials as they tried to move through the human barricade. The jostling continued for around one hour.

"The police acted beyond its jurisdiction. They forcefully entered my office although the billboard is placed on the roof, including women of my office staff, were injured. We will move the Calcutta high court tomorrow," Banerjee said on Facebook Live at 5:57 pm when KMC workers were removing the billboard. mrc

STUDENTS CALL OFF PATNA STIR AFTER STATE GOVT ACCEPTS DEMANDS

Arun Kumar
letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: The students' representative on Thursday ended their agitation demanding a single-tier Public Service Commission (BPCS) Teachers' Recruitment Examination (TRE)-4 after a five-member committee headed by state education minister Rajiv Roshan held talks with them.

It was the 11th day of the students' agitation and the government accepted their demands to hold the exam in one phase, instead of two, with this the hunger strike by two students Aman and Jaanvi was finally broken.

The main demand of the agitating students was that there should be single-phase TRE-4, instead of two tier, and single result for single candidate, unlike earlier when one candidate qualified for multiple posts. They also went to the residence of education minister Mihlesh's Thirai to apprise him of their demands.

Chief minister Samrat Choudhary immediately took to X to post that the government has been serious about the students' demands from the very beginning.

"Now, a decision has been taken regarding the students' demands that this year's TRE-4 examination will be conducted in one phase. Along with this, 9 other important decisions have also been made," he added.

Choudhary said that the state government has constituted a "Special Expert Committee on Examination Reforms" to provide recommendations for improvements in various examinations. "This committee, chaired by a judge of the Patna High Court, will also hear students' complaints related to various examinations," he added.

Sugar prices ease marginally 1st time in a week

Pallavi Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Retail sugar prices finally fell Thursday after continuing their rise, a day after the all-India average touched ₹65.06 a kg, with the Centre's decision to allow duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar beginning to take effect.

The all-India average retail price fell to ₹64.33 a kg from ₹65.06 on Wednesday, according to the consumer affairs ministry's daily price data. It had risen from ₹55.73 a kg on August 20 to ₹65.06 on August 26.

"Wholesale and mill prices

THIS COMES AFTER THE CENTRE'S PUSH FOR DUTY-FREE IMPORTS OF 1 MILLION TONNES OF RAW SUGAR BEGAN TO COOL THE MARKET

had begun to ease, but retail prices remained sticky as they typically lag behind. Even though 11 still doubt whether sufficient quantities are actually available in the market, the wholesale

price fall has begun to show up in retail. Agri expert and head of HNB Deepak Pareek said.

The Centre had allowed duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar on August 20, the first such move in nearly a decade, to boost domestic supplies ahead of the festival season as ex-mill prices touched a record high of ₹71.00 per 100 kg in some states.

Retail prices, however, remain sharply above previous levels. Thursday's average was about 31% higher than a month ago and 39% above a year earlier, when sugar retail at ₹46.40 a

kg. The government has attributed the price rise to lower production, weather-related crop damage and higher festive demand, stating that there is no physical shortage and that speculative buying contributed to the surge.

Meanwhile, Congress general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala alleged that the Union government deliberately allowed shortage of sugar despite having advance knowledge of a decline in production and buffer stocks resulting in a scam of ₹36,000 crore on consumers during the four-month festive season.

REGISTRATIONS IN IIT-K'S SATHEE RISE AFTER GOVT'S FREE COACHING PUSH

Sanjay Maurya
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kanpur's free online coaching platform Self-Assessment, Test and Help for Entrance Exams (SATHEE) has witnessed a sharp surge in registrations after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's August 15 announcement of a national network for free online coaching.

The institute is now working with the Union education ministry to develop a new platform that will build on SATHEE's experience, with upgraded content, user interface, artificial intelligence (AI) and infrastructure.

SATHEE recorded 154,000 new registrations between August 15 and 22, compared with 200-300 a day before the announcement, according to data reviewed by HT.

Registrations peaked at 41,600 on August 18 from 5,100 on August 15, before falling to 7,100 on August 22.

100 days in power, the hits and misses of UDF

Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The VD Satheesan-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government completed 100 days in office on August 26, following a 102-seat landslide victory in May that ended a decade in opposition.

Satheesan trumped his party colleagues KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala to the state's top post after nearly two weeks of hectic deliberations in Delhi.

Here are some of the important decisions undertaken during his 100-day-long tenure:

Privatization scheme
Delivered free KSRTC ordinary bus travel for women of all backgrounds, supported by an annual ₹800 crore state allocation.

Welfare hikes
The government, in its first cabinet meeting, approved a ₹3,000 hike for ASHAs and ₹1,000 increase for anganwadi workers, midday meal staff and pre-primary teachers.



UDF

Operation Toofan
A drive against drugs, Operation Toofan, has led to the arrest of over 10,000, and seizure of 8.24 kg of MDMA and 579 kg of ganja till August 12.

However, four of the five core election promises, including free pension hikes, student financial aid, health cover, and interest-free startup loans, remain stalled due to state financial constraints.

PM-SHRI row
The cabinet's move to implement PM-SHRI scheme in the state has ticked off key coalition ally UML.

Vizhinjam port row
The announcement regarding Mediterranean Shipping Company securing a 49% stake in the Adani-led Vizhinjam port without informing the government turned into a political slugfest. Opposition has alleged the CM's hand in the investment deal and alleged that it would lead to MISC monopolising the port's operations.

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Sunday Hindustan Times

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, readers who are readers had a bonus quiz with the last word, and cross appear in a financial village. Have guessed this week. Take the quiz to find out.

Answers: 1. The author of the book 'The Great Gatsby' is F. Scott Fitzgerald. 2. The word 'quintessential' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 3. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 4. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 5. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 6. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 7. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 8. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 9. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 10. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 11. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 12. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 13. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 14. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 15. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 16. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 17. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 18. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 19. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 20. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 21. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 22. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 23. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 24. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 25. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 26. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 27. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 28. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 29. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 30. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 31. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 32. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 33. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 34. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 35. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 36. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 37. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 38. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 39. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 40. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 41. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 42. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 43. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 44. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 45. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 46. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 47. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 48. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 49. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 50. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 51. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 52. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 53. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 54. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 55. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 56. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 57. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 58. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 59. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 60. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 61. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 62. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 63. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 64. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 65. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 66. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 67. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 68. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 69. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 70. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 71. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 72. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 73. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 74. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 75. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 76. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 77. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 78. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 79. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 80. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 81. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 82. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 83. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 84. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 85. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 86. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 87. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 88. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 89. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 90. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 91. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 92. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 93. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 94. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 95. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 96. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 97. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 98. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 99. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 100. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 101. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 102. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 103. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 104. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 105. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 106. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 107. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 108. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 109. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 110. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 111. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 112. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 113. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 114. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 115. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 116. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 117. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 118. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 119. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 120. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 121. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 122. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 123. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 124. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 125. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 126. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 127. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 128. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 129. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 130. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 131. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 132. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 133. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 134. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 135. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 136. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 137. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 138. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 139. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 140. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 141. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 142. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 143. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 144. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 145. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 146. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 147. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 148. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 149. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 150. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 151. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 152. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 153. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 154. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 155. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 156. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 157. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 158. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 159. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 160. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 161. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 162. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 163. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 164. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 165. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 166. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 167. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 168. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 169. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 170. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 171. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 172. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 173. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 174. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 175. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 176. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 177. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 178. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 179. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 180. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 181. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 182. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 183. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 184. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 185. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 186. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 187. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 188. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 189. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 190. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 191. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 192. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 193. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 194. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 195. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 196. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 197. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 198. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 199. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 200. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 201. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 202. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 203. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 204. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 205. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 206. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 207. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 208. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 209. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 210. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 211. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 212. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 213. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 214. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 215. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 216. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 217. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 218. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 219. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 220. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 221. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 222. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 223. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 224. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 225. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 226. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 227. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 228. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 229. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 230. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 231. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 232. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintessence'. 233. The word 'quintessence' is derived from the word 'quintess



Man in SUV mows down guard at Indore colony

INDORE: A security guard stopped and reprimanded an SUV driver for speeding in a housing colony in Indore only to be crushed to death by the vehicle in a fit of rage by the motorist, a police official said on Thursday. Police said they have registered a case of murder against the driver, Raja Kumawat.

India-Nepal bus service put on hold: Delhi govt

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has temporarily put on hold the 'Indo-Nepal Maitri Bus Sewa' for the next two days due to massive flash floods, an official order said on Thursday. According to officials, road transportation has been shut on the Delhi-Kathmandu Route after the flash floods.

SC to hear plea over sand mining in Ken river

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed the listing of a plea flagging illegal sand mining in Madhya Pradesh's Ken River threatening the ecosystem around the Panna Tiger Reserve and Ken Gharial Sanctuary with suo motu proceedings on Chambal sanctuary.

NEPAL FLOODS

another major flood," NDRRMA said on 3. China warned that 3 million cubic meters of water — the equivalent of about 1,200 Olympic swimming pools — are expected to flow into an already-dammed lake on its side of the border over the next three days, creating a high risk of a breach, with peak flow expected around September 1. In India, families across eight states prayed for the safe return of their loved ones — most of them working at a power project in Nepal or Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims — even as hours turned into days with no word on their relatives' safety.

"All 13 including my brother's family were in Rasuwa...The tour operators said they are also unable to get any information about the whereabouts of the whole group. Getting connected to the helpline in Nepal is also a problem because of connectivity and the language barrier," Viswanathan Venkatesh, who is based in Sydney, said. A group of pilgrims from Tamil Nadu, whose bus narrowly escaped the cascading floods, thanked their fate. "There were around 60 people in our troupe. We managed to escape but do not know what happened to others," Navu Kobirios, a Chennai resident, said on the phone to HT.

He added: "We were shifted to an army base camp near Kathmandu in helicopters. I am doing fine. We want to speak to our families." Initial assessments based on seismic and satellite data indicate the flood was triggered by the collapse of a glacier in the Himalayan region between Nepal and Tibet on Wednesday, causing a 5.2-magnitude seismic event that sent columns of water, ice, rock and debris

downstream, according to the US Geological Survey. Ice from the glacier may then have blocked the Lhunde Khola river, causing water to quickly accumulate and ultimately surge downstream.

"What we've certainly confirmed — there was a large ice avalanche, probably a mixture of ice and rock, which detached and then became fluid and then transformed into this devastating flood," said Simon Allen, a research associate at the University of Zurich who studies glacial hazards in the Himalayas.

The resultant deluge was so intense that waves reached as high as nine meters in 30 minutes on the Trishuli river, according to the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development. Images showed what appeared to be the second floors of buildings in Nepal's hard-hit Nuwakot district skidded in mud after the torrent rushed by. Debris hung from tree branches and wires, vehicles were buried and some stunned survivors were caked in mud.

Before-and-after images aired by state broadcaster China Central Television showed a multi-story building and more than a dozen vehicles covered in mud. A two-lane road running along a river in a valley in Tibet's Shigatse prefecture was completely buried. Aerial footage also showed that a lake had formed and expanded on the China-Nepal border.

Videos of the disaster showed people running before the floodwaters swallowed them up and washed out buildings and bridges. India said it stood 'shoulder-to-shoulder' with Nepal with external affairs minister S Jaishankar — after a high-level meeting with top officials and India's envoys to Kathmandu and Bei-

jing — saying New Delhi was making "urgent efforts" to ascertain the status and well-being of Indians stuck in flood-hit areas. Since Wednesday night, India has sent a total of 47.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in two military transport aircraft and is in the process of sending more relief materials. The first tranche of relief materials was sent hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to his Nepalese counterpart Balendra Shah and assured him of all possible humanitarian assistance to deal with the situation.

"The situation is still challenging. All state mechanisms are operating at full capacity. Right now, our first priority is to save the lives of each and every citizen, search and rescue of the missing, treat the injured and provide immediate relief to the affected families," Shah said in a statement.

Among the worst hit on the nearly 100-km stretch — bustling with thousands of trekkers, traders and pilgrims — were Kailash Mansarovar Yatra devotees.

"The first group of 73 people who are working on the Trishuli-I power project. Our embassy in Kathmandu is in touch with the project head to get more details about these people...Then, two separate groups of 37 and 49 nationals from Tamil Nadu, who travelled for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra through Samrat and Fly Everest Travels. There is a group of 32 Indian nationals from West Bengal who travelled with the help of Samrat Travels in Timure, which is in Rasuwa district. Then, a group of 61 Indian nationals from different states...and then a group of 33 Indian nationals from Kerala. These are five major groups who comprise, by and large, 288 people that we are talking about," said external affairs ministry spokesperson

Randhir Jaiswal.

The deluge — the worst natural disaster to strike Nepal since the 2015 earthquake that killed nearly 9,000 — underlined the impact of the climate crisis that has accelerated the ongoing thaw in the Himalayas, an area that holds more snow and ice than any place on Earth besides the Arctic and Antarctica.

MODI VISIT

nese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif are among the leaders expected to attend the summit.

During his address at the summit, Modi will highlight India's priorities such as security, connectivity and opportunity, the ministry said.

The SCO was established with the primary goal of countering terror, separatism and extremism, which remain a challenge. Sibi George, secretary (West) in the ministry, told a media briefing, India became a full member of the grouping in 2017.

During the visit to Kyrgyzstan, the Prime Minister is also scheduled to attend the opening of the sixth World Nomad Games, which celebrate the cultural heritage of Central Asia. In Uzbekistan, which Modi is visiting for the fourth time, he will hold talks with President Shavkat Mirziyoyev to strengthen the bilateral strategic partnership. The two leaders will review cooperation in trade and investment, energy, digital connectivity, defence, education and people-to-people ties, the ministry said.

Modi is expected to visit the Lal Bahadur Shastri memorial in Tashkent and the Mahatma Gandhi Centre at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies.

4 KILLED IN MANIPUR

The deceased, all Liangmai Naga leaders, were identified as Tadsongbou Ringkangmai, founder and principal of Right Path School; T Khullen; Mariakdibou Wijnunamai, executive member of Makui Youth Club; Wisobou Charenamai, chairman of the Chawangkning Village Authority; and Anji Wijnunamai, executive member of Makui Youth Club, according to officials.

One Gaikamang Ringkangmai sustained injuries in the attack.

Officials said intense firing was reported after the attack. The circumstances leading to the incident and the identities of those responsible were not immediately established by officials.

The United Naga Council (UNC), the apex body of the organisation, accused two Kuki militant outfits — Kuki National Front (P) and Kuki Revolutionary Army (KRA) — of being involved in the ambush. The Naga People's Organisation (NPO) forced shops and businesses establishments in Senapati district headquarters town to down shutters. The UNC also announced a 12-hour shutdown from 6 am in all Naga areas of the state on Friday. The strike is likely to impact normal life in the hill districts.

"Expressing our collective mourning and paying homage to our fallen brothers, a one-day Genna shall be observed in all Naga areas and district headquarters from 6 am to 6 pm on August 28. During the stipulated period of Genna, all vehicular movement, shops & business establishments, government offices, and private & government institutions shall remain closed," UNC said in a statement.

This is the largest casualty in the strife-torn state since May 13 and pushes the death toll in the three-year-long violence to nearly 300 with security experts cautioning that the grisly murders could ratchet up tensions in the restive province.

This is the gravest crisis in the state since the swearing-in of chief minister Y Khenchand Singh on February 4 this year who was sworn in hours after the lifting of the President's Rule, which restored popularly elected democratic government to the state that reeled under violence since May 2023, when ethnic clashes first broke out between the dominant Meitei and tribal Kuki communities. Since then, almost every community has been engulfed by the spiralling violence that led to a complete breakdown of law and order, the creation of ethnic enclaves, the displacement of 66,000 people, and a virtual bifurcation of the state.

The Naga community was initially not a part of the strife but was pulled into the violence on May 13, when — in a twin ambush carried out at Noney district and Kangpokpi district — four civilians were killed by unknown assailants, including three church leaders and one Naga man.

On the same day, 48 civilians belonging to both Kuki and Naga communities were taken hostage by people from either groups.

Two days later, 14 people from each community were set free. But 14 Kuki civilians and six Naga civilians remained captured.

After 27 days of protest and appeals for unconditional release of both the hostages, UNC, along with other Naga civil bodies, released 14 Kuki civilians on June 9.

But on June 10, mutilated

bodies of six Naga hostages were recovered, ratcheting up tensions.

Makui Village Authority — representing the village where the victims came from — alleged that Kuki militants were responsible for the attack, demanded the immediate arrest of those responsible, and said both the state and central governments must take full responsibility for the safety of Naga civilians in Kangpokpi district.

Deputy chief minister Losi Dikho expressed strong condemnation of the incident that he described as a "heinous and barbaric attack on innocent Naga civilians allegedly by Kuki militants".

"He asserted that the deliberate targeting of innocent civilians is utterly reprehensible and cannot be justified under any circumstances," a statement issued by his office said.

"He appealed to all sections of the people to remain resolute in rejecting violence in all its forms... collective resolve for peace must be stronger than forces seeking to divide the people," the statement added.

In the evening, Dikho held a high-level meeting in Senapati with a delegation of UNC. Bharatiya Janata Party lawmaker Tongbram Robinro also attended the meeting, a government official said on condition of anonymity.

The discussions focused on the prevailing situation and the need to promote peace and stability. Senior officials and personnel from the Central Reserve Police Force, Assam Rifles and Senapati Police were also present. The deputy CM's office said in a statement.

The Kuki Zo Council did not issue a statement on the incident. The Manipur Police did not comment or provide details on the killings.

Fadnavis gives auto and taxi drivers across Maharashtra 1 year to learn Marathi

Saurabha Kulkreshtha
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday announced a one-year extension for the auto and taxi drivers to learn Marathi, adding that no action would be taken against them till then. The announcement came days after transport minister and Shiv Sena leader Pratap Sarnaik announced that the licences of auto and taxi drivers who are unable to speak Marathi would be suspended after three months if they failed to learn the language.

A delegation of auto and taxi drivers led by Haji Arzaf Shahi who is the leader of the BJP's transport wing, met Fadnavis on Thursday. They pointed out that a huge number of drivers could not speak Marathi, and it was not possible for them to acquire a working knowledge of the language in just three months. When they demanded extra time and protection against the action by the transport department, Fadnavis agreed to give them relief.

Speaking to the media after the meeting, Fadnavis said, "This afternoon, a delegation of auto and taxi drivers met me and requested additional time to learn Marathi. Most of them are not very educated so they will require more time. I have decided to give them a year's extension, and from today, no action will be taken against them for a year."

Shahik thanked Fadnavis for



Devendra Fadnavis

the relief. "We welcome the decision announced by the CM," he said. "Some people were attempting to play politics with the Marathi issue. But now CM Fadnavis has addressed the concerns of drivers."

Sarnaik also welcomed the decision. "We had given drivers 105 days to learn Marathi," he said. "But now that they have a full year, we hope they will study well and speak fluent Marathi." He added that no other extension would be given to the drivers.

Sarnaik had announced in April that as per the rules, auto and taxi drivers needed to have a working knowledge of Marathi, failing which their permits would be cancelled. After several rounds of discussion with unions, he announced Marathi classes for the drivers at which 1,65,000 learnt Marathi before the August 15 deadline. RTIs across Maharashtra launched a drive from August 18 to test the drivers. Those who failed were issued show cause notices and given three months' time to learn the language.

LOW-SPEED E-BIKES MAY BE EXEMPTED FROM MV RULES

Soumya Chatterjee
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Centre has proposed changes to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, that would exclude certain low-powered, two-wheeled, battery-operated vehicles from being treated as motor vehicles under the Motor Vehicles Act. The draft rules, notified by the ministry of road transport and highways published on Thursday, propose that the changes come into force from October 1, 2026.

Under the proposed definition, a two-wheeled, battery-operated vehicle would not be deemed a motor vehicle if a specified testing agency verifies that it has an electric motor with a 30-minute power of less than 0.6 kW and a maximum speed below 25 kmph. For pedal-assisted vehicles with an auxiliary electric motor, the draft additionally requires the motor's 30-minute power to be below 0.6 kW and its output to progressively reduce and finally cut off when the vehicle reaches 25 kmph, or sooner if the cyclist stops pedalling. The vehicles covered by the provision would also have to comply with specified safety requirements under AIS-049 (Rev.1).

Venugurum S, senior advisor at National Council of Applied Economic Research and former road safety scientist at Central Road Research Institute expressed concern, saying the vehicles could be used by children, while raising questions over third-party insurance in the event of a fatal crash. "At least, if they make helmet use mandatory, it makes good sense,"

HAVE FUN WITH FACTS ON SUNDAYS

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

Take a cue from the clues

Two IAF jets crash in training, 1 pilot dead

India's rocket despite bids to break, in hell

Chinese army releases Annuchal Prakashan

HAVE FUN WITH FACTS ON SUNDAYS

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

Take a cue from the clues

Two IAF jets crash in training, 1 pilot dead

India's rocket despite bids to break, in hell

Chinese army releases Annuchal Prakashan

Dark portents of Nepal flood

Each Himalayan tragedy only signals the next one. Business as usual is no longer defensible

Thousands are missing and at least 320 dead after a wall of ice and rock broke off a mountainside on the Tibetan side of the Nepal-China border on the morning of August 26 and cascaded through the Lhende-Bhote Koshi-Trishuli river system. Six major hydropower plants have been destroyed, a Nepal-China border crossing has been washed away, and—in what captures how the severe event was—the collapse registered as a magnitude 5.2 earthquake, with the seismic signal read by earthquake monitoring centres around the world.

The exact trigger will take months of analysis to pin down, but the early signs point in one direction: the climate crisis. The mountain region where the collapse originated has been warming at several times the global average. Peer-reviewed work published only weeks before the disaster, mapping the immediately adjacent glacier system in Nepal, found that more than 40% of the ice cover documented at the end of the Little Ice Age is now gone, that the loss is accelerating, and that a specific process—high-elevation ice fragmenting and detaching from the slopes it rests on—is becoming the dominant mode of glacier retreat across the Himalaya. That is the process now suspected of causing the tragedy in Nepal's Rasuwa. Its authors, writing in *Global and Planetary Change*, explicitly flagged the geohazards likely to follow.

Rasuwa is not the first such warning. The Sikkim flood of October 2023, which destroyed the Teesta III hydropower project and killed dozens; the Thame flood in Nepal's Everest region in 2024; and a smaller flash flood along the same Rasuwa-Gyirong corridor last July—all fit the same profile. Each has, in policy terms, been treated as a discrete tragedy.

From Uttarakhand to Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh, India faces the same Himalayan threats, with the risks only turbocharged by faster warming, ice thinning at high elevations, slopes progressively destabilised by unchecked construction. Populations have swelled, hill towns have spread beyond any load the geology was ever meant to carry, and construction—of highways, hydropower projects, tunnels, hotels—has proceeded with little regard for what the mountains above are doing. A national audit of Himalayan projects and settlements, including population numbers, is overdue. Each Himalayan tragedy only portends the next one. Business as usual, in construction, in settlement policy, in how these disasters are absorbed and forgotten, is no longer defensible.

Meta payout must be seen as a lesson for all

Meta's \$18 billion settlement—one of the largest in US history—with 48 American states and three territories may look like poetic justice. The social media giant is said to have faced its reckoning over alarming practices to prioritise revenue, causing severe harm to some of its most vulnerable user groups. It raises an important question, though: Is the settlement punitive enough? There are two considerations here. First, the payout itself. Meta settled the 2023 lawsuit—over fuelling social media addiction, misleading the public about harm, and data privacy breaches—within days of the trial beginning. Whether the company dodged a much larger anticipated penalty or wished to avoid more damning disclosures remains a matter of conjecture. What is clear, however, is that we will not pinch Meta too much, being even less than the company's profit in the last quarter of 2025 (\$23 billion). To be sure, quantifying the harm Meta products caused to millions of American children and adolescents over years may be difficult. What makes the payout feel deficient even further is that a significant part of it is tied to Meta competitors such as TikTok, YouTube, and others inking similar agreements.

The more important part of the deal is the operational and design changes Meta will make to protect young users against mental health harm. Stricter changes remain contingent upon similar actions by competitors and on tech-tools that are not hard to beat.

The payout should be seen as a warning, nevertheless. This newspaper has been regularly pointing out the need to protect adolescents from social media and digital harm in India. In the absence of self-regulation, the State needs to intervene, as several countries have already done. Digital behemoths must demonstrate effective course correction to avoid harder and broader responses to their practices.

Indian industry must wake up to new order

The shift from a rules-based world order to an increasingly transactional paradigm means there are major threats for business-as-usual

After the new US Administration took office in 2025, the policies announced signalled that the old global economic order had ruptured. The post-World War II system—built broadly around comparative advantage, multilateral trade rules and institutions such as the WTO—gave way to a more transactional world of beggar thy neighbour and might is right.

Within months, several assumptions underpinning the global order were broken. Tariffs were weaponised. Industrial installed capacity was weaponised. Access to critical minerals, large language models, and semiconductor supply chains, shipping routes, and supply chains. Economic security and national security became inseparable. Sanctions could be imposed or withdrawn as part of transactional deal-making. The distinction between allies and adversaries blurred. The new sources of power were increasingly clear: economic and military might, nuclear capability, control over critical raw materials and technologies, and influence over dollar-based payment systems.

Indian industry better wake up—there is a major threat for 'business as usual' and an extraordinary opportunity for those that can pivot.

First, a short historical tour. India's economic policy adopted at Independence created a fair degree of path dependency. India's growth model was highly impacted by the fact that it along with just another 20 countries, offered its citizens universal adult franchise in 1947. As with all democracies, its polity had to be very responsive to the electorate. So, the voter demands and obtained subsidies, support prices, and welfare payments. These were provided by the government. Not only that, in return for offering generous amounts of protection (over 130% industry was forced to cross subsidise the voter, subsidising rail travel, power, and capital costs. High tariff walls led to poor quality, little need for research and development investments as the Indian consumer was captive and created export pessimism.

Jawaharlal Nehru's policy to see the State occupy the 'commanding heights' in the economy developed by 1970 into a full-fledged Licence Raj, where government approvals were required for production levels, product lines, and capacity expansion. The State also entered most sectors—banking, insurance, oil and gas, steel, coal, telecommunications, power generation and distribution. So much so that public sector companies ran hotels and made bread. This led to all the expected inefficiencies, low growth rates, fiscal profligacy,

leading ultimately to the balance of payments crisis in 1990.

The economic reforms that were necessitated in 1991 removed many of the worst distortions, devalued the rupee, lowered tariffs and freed prices, and removed some arcane regulations. But the economy remained protected, heavily regulated with a high degree of State control. Infrastructure with increased growth became a big constraint. Post 2000, what did grow were services exports and non-resident Indian remittances. This allowed us to run a modest (1.5% of GDP) current account deficit on account of oil, gas, and gold with which the policy establishment got comfortable. These reforms changed the growth trajectory of the economy to an impressive 6.5% per annum but not the essential model.

Government actions post 2014 recognised that the massive gaps in infrastructure were strangulating the economy and boosted infrastructure spending. The decade 2014-24 saw the creation of 60,000 km of roads, 100 airports, 210 GW of additional power generation, increases in rail and port capacity, 35 million low-cost homes, and a palpably stronger domestic business environment. The passage of the Goods and Service Tax and Insolvency and Bankruptcy Act further provided for data centres, in addition to exploration in the sea was permitted, and the need for R&D was signalled by creating an R&D fund. India worked hard to not get shut out of global mar-



Janmejay Sinha

kets by signing nine bilateral free trade agreements covering 38 countries. While some important areas of reform remain—contract enforcement, subsidy regime rationalisation, financial sector reforms among others—the overall message is clear.

FTAs mean we will need to defend our domestic business as much as we try and take advantage of the markets opening to us. In the new era winners will compete on global quality, best service or lowest cost. Indian industry must study every FTA market for opportunity. It needs to shed its complacency and up R&D spend. Industry must develop innovative models to attract talent back, build centres of excellence in critical technologies in their own global capability centres in India. They must stop lobbying for tariffs on raw materials and intermediate goods for India to take advantage of the signed FTAs. We have about three years to get ready before the FTAs become fully operational. Our economy is robust, corporate and bank balance sheets are strong, and our entrepreneurial class is the best in the world. But the old order is dead. Time to wake up. The world awaits!

Janmejay Sinha is chairman, BCG India. The views expressed are personal

{ VITAL SIGNS }

Ramanan Laxminarayan

When regulations go beyond bigger sticks

Have you noticed how a motorcyclist who always wears a helmet on the main road may sometimes ride without one on a quiet road inside your colony? He has not necessarily decided that a head injury is no longer dangerous but simply thinks that the chance of being stopped by a policeman is much smaller.

This is a basic problem with regulation. A rule backed only by the threat of punishment works only if people believe they will be caught. Where enforcement is infrequent, the rational response may be to ignore the rule if the cost of complying is greater than the perceived chance of being punished. This problem shows up in any attempt to regulate for health and safety. We tend to tell people what not to do and punish them when they are caught. But this approach doesn't work when there is insufficient enforcement, a common problem in a country as large as India. The State has to find the people breaking the rules, which then requires inspectors, careful documentation of violations and imposition of penalties, while also contending with the possibility of bribery undermining the system. Can regulation be designed better so that people and businesses have a reason to do the right thing even when nobody is watching?

We have to step back to see that the basic purpose of regulation is not to produce compliance. Rather, it is to produce the outcome for which the regulation was created. When we see governments report thousands of inspections, fines and prosecutions and still have dangerous roads, polluted air or unsafe workplaces, it shows that the measures of regulatory activity are not a good proxy for regulatory success. Smart regulation requires a combination of sticks and carrots but, in India, we are far quicker to reach for the stick than the carrot. Carrots, though, have many advantages.

Take the case of road safety, a big issue in India, with over 170,000 road deaths each year, including over 35,000 pedestrians. The current approach is to use speed breakers everywhere, which slows down traffic for everyone—a cost that defeats the purpose of having good roads in the first place. Sweden has experimented with insurance discounts for drivers who demonstrate that they stay within speed limits, using electronic monitoring to verify their behaviour. Singapore combines penalties for traffic violations with rewards for drivers who maintain a clean record, including insurance discounts. The principle could be extended in India to provide lower insurance premiums to commercial fleets that can demonstrate sustained reductions in speeding, harsh braking and other risky driving could achieve outcomes much more easily than slowing down traffic.

The same approach could apply to businesses. In Germany, workplace insurance systems reward employers with better safety records with lower premiums. This approach can be adopted in India, where factories that consistently demonstrate compliance with occupational safety standards could similarly receive lower insurance costs and faster regulatory approvals. A point system, if you will, for good corporate behaviour, that is made public so that there are opportunities for public input. Instead of waiting for an inspector to

discover a violation, the employer would have a financial need to maintain and document a safe workplace.

Food safety offers another example. Instead of relying on periodic inspections to find unhygienic restaurants, establishments that maintain independent, verified records of food safety practices could receive a graded certification, displayed prominently for customers to see. This is fairly common in most US cities—once you see the restaurant's safety rating even before entering the establishment. It is only if the restaurant is deemed unsafe that it is shut down. But a rating of C compared to an A rating is likely to discourage customers even without having shut down the restaurant, which would then aspire to improve its rating. Basically, this incentive works because the restaurant has something to gain from maintaining standards even when an inspector is not present. And customers have information they can use when choosing where to eat.

Antibiotic resistance is a major problem—an estimated 297,000 annual deaths in India are directly attributable to bacterial antimicrobial resistance because pharmacies encourage the overuse and misuse of antibiotics, including for viral infections against which antibiotics have no effect. Pharmacies that maintain verified records of appropriate antibiotic dispensing could receive a recognised stewardship certification, while repeated inappropriate dispensing would attract penalties. Accredited pharmacies would then be allowed to dispense newer antibiotics because they have shown their reliability with existing ones.

There is another advantage to the carrot. Enforcement requires the State to find bad behaviour whereas incentives give people a reason to demonstrate good behaviour. With incentive-based regulation, a pharmacy seeking to be allowed to dispense newer antibiotics or a factory seeking a lower insurance premium would willingly provide information that documents their behaviour because they now have an incentive to do so. Regulation, therefore, becomes less a contest between an inspector and someone trying to evade the rules, and more a system in which evidence generation is encouraged. This is not to say that incentive-based systems cannot be gamed, but trying these out in some states to see how well they work compared to the current system is well worth the effort.

All this requires a fundamental mindset change in the bureaucracy from treating every citizen or business as a potential law-breaker to being a participant in a society looking to improve health and safety. When these outcomes are not being achieved, then it is time to rethink the laws rather than simply reaching for a bigger stick. We are also far too dependent on a competent officer being in the regulator's seat in order for laws to be enforced. Sadly, that is not always the case.

A smarter regulatory system for health and safety would make good behaviour economically attractive, so that behaviour may have, and reserve punishment for those who deliberately choose not to comply.

Ramanan Laxminarayan is president, One Health Trust. The views expressed are personal

{ LIN JIAN } SPOKESPERSON, FOREIGN MINISTRY, CHINA

The US is globally recognised as the world's biggest hacking & surveillance empire, its track record is notorious & the evidence is irrefutable

Responding to US seizing domains allegedly belonging to Chinese hacker groups

HT

States don't lose from new changes to the mining law

The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act of 2020 should be seen not merely as a fiscal or regulatory amendment, but as an important step towards preparing India for the future of the mining industry. At a time when minerals—particularly critical and strategic minerals—are becoming central to energy security, advanced manufacturing and economic resilience, India needs a mining framework that is predictable, competitive and capable of attracting long-term investment.

One of the biggest challenges before the mineral sector today is not the absence of resources or talent, but the gap between available technology and its large-scale deployment in mines. Artificial intelligence, automation, digital exploration, advanced mineral processing, resource recovery, and responsible mining will require substantial investment and stronger collaboration among industry, academia, and research institutions. Such investments come when the policy provides confidence and long-term visibility.

In this context, the scale of opportunity is significant. India holds over 1500 mineral blocks identified for auction and development, yet only a fraction are currently operational, indicating a large untapped potential for production expansion and value creation. The mining sector already contributes over 2% to India's GDP. With faster operationalisation of blocks, this share can grow substantially while also strengthening downstream industries such as steel, cement, batteries, and electronics.

India's dependence on imports further highlights the urgency of accelerating domestic mineral production. In FY 2025-26, India imported minerals worth \$10.12 crore, underscoring the need for self-reliance. For many forward-looking supply chains and reducing external vulnerability in critical minerals.

The reform is also timely from a revenue and investment perspective. India's mineral auction regime has already generated tens of thousands of crores in committed revenues for states through premiums, royalties, and statutory contributions such as the District Mineral Fund and via the National Mineral Exploration Trust, demonstrating that a structured auction system can be both transparent and fiscally strong. Importantly, of the total payments made by mining companies, nearly 96% of the revenue—including auction premiums, royalties, DMF, and other statutory levies—accrues directly to state governments. This revenue-sharing structure will remain unchanged even after the MMRD Amendment Act, 2026. In fact, over the past 12 years, the total revenue accrued to major min-

eral states has grown at a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 16.20%, reflecting the strengthening fiscal base of mineral-bearing states. During 2021-22 to 2025-26, major mining states collected more than \$85,000 crore in auction premium from just 100 auctioned mines, in addition to other revenue streams such as royalty, DMF, and GST. This clearly demonstrates that the larger opportunity lies not in auctioning and operationalising more mineral blocks, thereby expanding production and revenues, rather than increasing the number of taxes on minerals.

A more uniform and predictable fiscal framework can further improve investor confidence and make Indian mineral assets more attractive to various domestic and global players. Equally important is the need to bring mineral blocks to auction and subsequently into production much faster.

Currently, the time lag between resource identification and operational mining can extend to several years. Reducing this cycle even by 30-40% through better data systems, digital approvals, and institutional capacity can significantly increase mineral output and investment inflows. This is where technology-enabled governance becomes a critical enabler of reform.

For mineral-bearing states, the amendment should not be viewed as a loss of opportunity. On the contrary, more viable mines, more operational blocks, and greater investment ultimately mean a larger and more sustainable economic base for the states themselves. States continue to receive the majority of mining revenues, and faster production cycles directly translate into higher royalty inflows, job creation, and regional industrial development. The accompanying assessment also makes clear that the amendment is intended to preserve the existing revenue architecture of States while preventing an unpredictable additional fiscal burden that can make mining uneconomical.

This is, therefore, a futuristic and enabling reform—one that can help move India from simply allocating mineral resources to building a technologically advanced, investment-ready, and globally competitive mining ecosystem. The direction being provided by the Union government is particularly significant because it looks beyond the immediate question of revenue and towards the larger national objective of mineral security, industrial competitiveness, and the vision of *Viksit Bharat 2047*.

Dheeraj Kumar is Director, TEXMIN (TTRP, DST, GoI) & Professor (HAG), Indian School of Management (Indian School of Mines), Dhanbad. The views expressed are personal

WORLD

No talks with Iran, all options on table: US

Donald Trump has said he has 'no time schedule' to wrap up the war that completes six months today

Reuters & AFP
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON/TEHRAN: President Donald Trump said on Thursday that the United States is not talking with Iran as Washington focuses on punishing Tehran economically, vowing to penalise countries that do business with the Islamic Republic. "We don't want to speak to them. We're not looking to meet or anything," Trump told reporters in the Oval Office.

Earlier in the day, White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said the US economic campaign would continue until Iran decides to negotiate meaningfully. "Now we have Operation Economic Outcast to destroy their economy," Leavitt told the "Fox & Friends" programme. "No negotiations are happening right now, and this will continue until the president feels that maybe they come to the table in a meaningful way... He of course continues to retain all options on the table."

Iran, Qatar hold talks
Iran's top diplomat met his Qatari counterpart on Thursday in Tehran for talks on the strategic Strait of Hormuz, as a US naval blockade squeezes oil supplies to Iran amid a domestic shortfall.

The visit by Qatar's Foreign Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani follows a week of intense diplomacy in Iran involving separate meetings with Oman's top diplomat and senior Pakistani officials seeking ways to end the Middle East war and reopen Hormuz strait.



A US navy helicopter conducts a vertical replenishment for USS Boxer from USSNS Arctic in West Asia. U.S. CENTRAL COMMAND-X

U.S. FACING 'BEYOND CRITICAL' SHORTAGE OF PATRIOTS IN EUROPE DUE TO WEST ASIA WAR

WASHINGTON: The US military is experiencing a "beyond critical" shortage of advanced missile interceptors in Europe largely driven by President Donald Trump's war with Iran, a US defence official in Europe and a Nato official said, raising concerns about vulnerabilities in Nato countries to a potential Russian attack. The US defence official said the most concerning shortfall involves Patriot missile interceptors, which can shoot down Russia's high-speed ballistic missiles.

In the event of a Russian

ballistic missile assault on, for example, a military headquarters or power plant, Nato could be in a similar position to Patriot-starved Ukraine and be forced "to take punch after punch in the mouth," the US defence official said. In Europe, the American military "definitely" does not have enough Patriots to stop any possible sustained ballistic missile attack and would have "very limited" capability to defend against a single ballistic missile strike or a stray Russian missile that goes off course, the US official said. ASSOCIATED PRESS

efforts as well as the proposed framework for Hormuz between Iran and Oman.

Al Thani "emphasised the necessity of respecting the sovereignty of neighbouring states and freedom of navigation", and pursuing dialogue, the ministry said.

Alongside mediator Pakistan, Qatar had played a key role in securing an April ceasefire and June deal between Iran and the United States, but those deals have since collapsed.

Pakistan, Kuwait sign protocol on military ties

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan and Kuwait signed a defence cooperation protocol on Thursday to "significantly" expand military cooperation, Pakistan's defence ministry said. Pakistan's armed forces will support Kuwait in training, capacity building, border management and other areas of defence cooperation, the ministry said. REUTERS

Trump renames Lake Ontario as 'Lake America'

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said Thursday he is renaming Lake Ontario to be known as "Lake America" in the United States as he exacerbates his trade war with Canada. The Republican president signed an executive order that updated the lake's name for the US geographic naming service. Trump cannot force Canada to follow his preferred naming convention, however.

The move is reminiscent of his move last year to rename the Gulf of Mexico as the "Gulf of America". AP

Norway's King Harald, 89, in 'very serious' condition

OSLO: Norway's King Harald, 89, was in a "very serious" condition in hospital on Thursday, the royal court said. Hundreds of people gathered outside the Royal Palace in Oslo and in the centre of other major Norwegian cities, and many laid flowers as they awaited further news of the monarch's health. REUTERS

Russia moves to escalate war in Ukraine as talks hit dead end

Bloomberg, Reuters & AFP
letters@hindustantimes.com

MOSCOW/KYIV: Russia is preparing to escalate attacks on Ukraine after concluding that negotiations for a peace deal have reached a dead end, according to three people close to the Kremlin.

For now, Russia is weighing an intensification of powerful conventional ballistic missile attacks on Kyiv, including the centre of the capital, and infrastructure targets in other Ukrainian cities, the people said, asking not to be identified because the matter is sensitive.

Negotiation frameworks have effectively collapsed, leaving the two warring sides back at square one, the people said. President Vladimir Putin won't end the war under economic pressure from sanctions and Ukrainian attacks on Russian refineries and logistics networks, they said.

Moscow increasingly views the Ukrainian strikes as attacks by Nato states because alliance members supply Kyiv with weapons and intelligence.

Meanwhile, Russia warned on Thursday that it could strike Brit-



Investigators work on the site of a car explosion, which killed a military officer in St Petersburg, Russia on Thursday. REUTERS

ish military targets inside and outside Ukraine in response to Ukrainian attacks on targets inside Russia using long-range British cruise missiles.

'Scare stories'

The Kremlin on Thursday dismissed as "scare stories" US media reports suggesting that Russia could attack Nato, following a rare visit by the CIA director to Moscow. The Wall Street Journal and CBS News reported that CIA director John

Ratcliffe had sought to dissuade Russia from attacking Nato members, amid US intelligence assessments that Moscow could seek to test the alliance.

President Donald Trump on Thursday said Russia is "not going to attack" Nato territory, pushing back against media reports that Washington is concerned about a possible Russian move on Europe. Trump said he'd "had good talks" with President Vladimir Putin. "He's not going to be attacking a Nato territory."

Spending cuts

Russia imposed sharp spending restrictions after an April liquidity crisis exposed the mounting costs of its war in Ukraine. A tight austerity regime was introduced after Finance Minister Anton Siluanov warned Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin that there wouldn't be enough cash that month to make all the necessary payments on time, as the Treasury's federal budget balances fell to a negative 5.5 trillion rubles (\$65.3 billion), people close to the government said.

NIJJAR KILLING: CANADA POLICE WON'T CONFIRM AUTHENTICITY OF GOLDEY BRAR AUDIO

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: Canadian law enforcement is aware of an audio recording of a conversation featuring gangster Goldey Brar in which he claims credit for the killing of pro-Khalistan figure Hardeep Singh Nijjar on June 18, 2023.

"The RCMP is aware of reports regarding an audio recording circulating online that purportedly involves an individual discussing the homicide of Hardeep Singh Nijjar," a spokesperson for the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) informed HT in response to queries related to the audio. That audio remains unverified and the RCMP spokesperson said it was "not in a position to confirm, deny, authenticate, or otherwise comment on the origin, content, or evidentiary value of materials that have been published or shared publicly".

The clip featuring Satinderjeet Singh, better known as Goldey Brar has him taking credit for the murder, as Nijjar supported those that supplied narcotics to youth.

DISCORD SUE FOR \$100M IN CHILD SAFETY CASE: BRAZIL

RIO DE JANEIRO: The Brazilian government on Wednesday said it was suing the Discord messaging platform for nearly \$100 million in damages over its alleged failure to protect children from harmful content and demanded it adopt stronger safeguards. Brazil's National Data Protection Agency (ANPD) ordered Discord to suspend livestreams earlier this month after a 13-year-old girl was goaded into killing herself during a livestream.

The government said the lawsuit filed in Brasilia, was brought after failed negotiations with Discord, whose proposals were "deemed insufficient to eliminate the identified risks". AFP

Apple to launch foldable iPhone on Sept 9, kicking off Ternus era

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com

CALIFORNIA: Apple will hold its biggest product introduction of the year on September 9, kicking off the tenure of new chief executive officer John Ternus. The event will take place at Apple's headquarters in Cupertino, California, the company said on Wednesday.

Apple is poised to unveil new versions of the products that account for most of its revenue. This September event will be especially critical, as the company will use it to introduce its first foldable iPhone, entering a market dominated by Samsung.

As the iconic iPhone nears the 20th anniversary of its introduction, the new foldable design marks the biggest single change to the product's look. The device will be about the size of a standard passport, and it will open up to reveal a screen roughly the size of a small iPad.

Apple is also planning to introduce the iPhone 18 Pro and Pro Max, successors to its current high-end smartphones. The devices will feature faster chips, better battery life and major camera improvements, including a mechanical aperture on at least the larger model.

The event is also notable for what it won't include: a second-generation iPhone Air or regular iPhone 18. Instead, Apple is moving the release dates for those products to next spring, looking to smooth out its sales throughout the year. Those products will launch around the same time as a low-end iPhone 18e, new Macs and iPads.

Apple also has several other products in the pipeline for this year. New Apple Watches could arrive at the same time as the iPhones. And the company is readying a slate of home devices — including its first smart home hub with a screen, a fresh HomePod mini and an updated Apple TV set-top box — as well as an upgraded iPad mini.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



SPORT

ASIAN GAMES CUT
LEAVES WUSHU,
JUDO ATHLETES
CRYING FOUL

Avishek Roy
avishek.roy@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Sports Authority of India's decision to prune the Asian Games has irked several federations. Many federations are pointing out at the "ambiguity" in selection based on rankings, especially for squads picked on the basis of open trials.

Several sports, including tennis, rowing, judo, gymnastics, and weightlifting, have had their squads trimmed. SAI stuck to the ministry's selection criteria of at least top-6 finish at the Asian Championships or previous Asian Games as benchmark for individual athletes. For team sports, the benchmark was set at a top-8.

In wushu, for example, a squad of 12 was selected based on trials. SAI objected to five of them. Mercy Ngaimong, and the athletes have been omitted. "It is possible that in open trials, the athlete who wins in a weight class may not match the top-six (criteria)," said a Wushu Association of India official.

Even Arunachal Pradesh CM Pema Khandu wrote to sports minister Mansukh Mandavde asking him to consider Ngaimong based on her performance in the trials. Ngaimong, one of the leading wushu player won two gold medals at the 7th Nordic Open, Stockholm last year and silver in women's Jianshu at Oceania International Championship at Brisbane and at Moscow Wushu Stars.

In judo, only three of the 12 names have been approved, leaving out Glasgow Commonwealth Games gold medalist Harsh Singh and bronze medalist Unnati Sharma.

"They could have at least considered medal winners from the CWG. We have a scenario where CWG medal winners are not in the team, and those who have not won medal are in the team. Naturally, the CWG medal winners are shattered," said a judo official.

In tennis, five players have been excluded, including promising Vaishnavi Adkar and Manas Dhanne. That has led Rohan Bopanna question the selection process.

Of belief and hope: Djokovic begins his Slam quest, again

The last time Novak won a Slam was at the US Open in 2023 but he's been more than competitive since

Shahid Judge
shahid.judge@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The last time Novak Djokovic played a competitive singles tennis match, he spent quite a while bent down in pain. Often, he vomited into towels as he struggled with the heat and humidity at the Cincinnati Masters.

Yet, he refused to walk away mid-match, losing 6-2, 6-4, 6-4 against world No. 30 Thiago Agustín Tirante in a match that lasted two hours and 44 minutes. Since then though, he has had a lot more screentime, more so as the subject of the documentary 'Novak Djokovic: The World in Winter'.

In one particular sequence of the film, he addresses a topic that has been a raging debate across tennis in the past few years. "I know a lot of people are retiring me already, for many years," Djokovic said in the documentary. "Why would you want me to retire when I am still playing and competing at the highest level? I'm still top 5, top 10 in the world."

As it stands, he is the world No. 5. And at the US Open that begins on Sunday, he will compete as the fourth seed. He may not be the overwhelming favourite, yet he remains a player who cannot be written off.

The last time Djokovic won a Grand Slam was at the US Open in 2023. It was his 24th Major title, bringing him level with Margaret Court for the joint-all-time record. Since then, the 25th Slam has remained elusive, as he has become a step-slower with age, while his biggest opponents today, Janik Sinner and Carlos Alcaraz, have taken control of the

Novak Djokovic

Age 39

Grand Slam titles 24

Last GS title US Open 2023



RECORD AT SLAMS (SINCE LAST TITLE)

2 SLAM FINALS

6 SEMI-FINALS

1 QUARTER-FINAL

2 THIRD ROUND

BREAKDOWN

Year	Australian Open	French Open	Wimbledon	US Open
2024	SEMI-FINAL lost to Janik Sinner (opponent ranking: 4)	WALKOVER against Casper Ruud (7)	FINAL lost to Carlos Alcaraz (3)	ROUND 3 lost to Alexei Popyrin (28)
2025	SEMI-FINAL retired after first set against Alexander Zverev (2)	SEMI-FINAL lost to Janik Sinner (1)	SEMI-FINAL lost to Janik Sinner (1)	SEMI-FINAL lost to Carlos Alcaraz (2)
2026	FINAL lost to Carlos Alcaraz (1)	ROUND 3 lost to Joao Fonseca (30)	SEMI-FINAL lost to Janik Sinner (1)	*ONGOING

new world order of men's singles tennis. Djokovic now wants to produce his best at the Grand Slams. He may not have won a title in his last 11 attempts at the Majors, but his record at the Slams has still been impressive.

Since that triumph in New York City, in 2023, the Serbian's Grand Slam results include two third round finishes, one quarter-final, six semi-finals and the 2024 Wimbledon and 2026 Australian Open

finals. These results include a walkover to Casper Ruud in the quarter-final of the French Open (2024) and a mid-match retirement (against Alexander Zverev at the 2025 Australian Open semi-final). It also includes four defeats to current world No. 1 Sinner and three to Alcaraz.

The only anomalies were defeats to then world No. 28 Alexei Popyrin (third round of US Open 2024) and to then world No. 30

Joao Fonseca, in the third round of the French Open earlier this year.

These are performances most players would dream of, but Djokovic holds himself to higher standards. "Whenever Novak enters any tournament, or a Major, he'll be in it with a shot. Not just once, not just here, he's done it every place, and at the highest levels," Roger Federer, one of Djokovic's great rivals, said ahead of the US Open. "I always think that as long

as he's in the draw, there's a chance. That's one of the reasons he's still playing, because he truly must believe that he can still do it."

To better prepare himself for the Slams, Djokovic has actively been truncating his tennis calendar. In 2024, he played in 12 tournaments, which included the triumph at the Paris Olympics and a single Davis Cup match. In 2025, he played in 13 tournaments. But in an injury-ridden 2026, he has played in only three competitions so far, including the opening round loss at Cincinnati.

"It's just a condition that I have, health-wise, that has been bothering me for the past couple of years," Djokovic said after losing to Tirante. "It causes a lot of issues, especially when it is humid and it is hot."

He may have to deal with those conditions again, with New York often being hot and humid at this time of the year. As for dealing with nerves though, he is a different beast. He often wins the mental battle before even taking to the court – especially in the grueling best-of-five set matches. What's been struggling with of late though is the physical aspect.

That has led to a few changes to his game style. A defensive baseliner at heart, he no longer prefers longer rallies. And so, he tends to mix-up play, throwing in drop shots and charging up to the net.

"Survive to thrive," he said after reaching the quarter-final at Wimbledon this year. "Hopefully the thriving part is coming."

Since winning his first Grand Slam title, at the Australian Open in 2008, Djokovic has never gone three consecutive seasons without winning a Major. The US Open will, in one way or another, mark a first for him – either a third season without a Slam, or a new world record.

He will hope the thriving part is indeed coming soon.

India must master more Olympic sports: PM Modi

HT Correspondent
sportdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said India must expand its base and participate in more sporting disciplines to enhance its medal prospects at the Olympics.

Modi was speaking to participants at the Khelo India Samvaad via video conference, addressing youth and athletes who connected from over 5,000 institutes across the country as part of the National Sports Day 2026 celebrations.

"Other countries are winning medals in sports where India does not even participate; we must master these sports as well which is important to increase our medal tally," said PM Modi.

"The bitter truth is that we don't even compete in half the sporting disciplines at the Olympics, which means that we are not competing for a big part of the medal tally, and it has been happening for decades. In the 2012 Olympics, India participated in just 13 sports and did not compete in more than 20 events. Other countries win medals in these sports and we don't even take part."

"To increase our medal tally we have to participate in sports such as surfing, sport climbing etc. We have such a huge coastline and mountainous region that such sports should come naturally to us. Whether it is watersports or

PM Narendra Modi.

winter sports, we have the demography and the geography but we are not seen in such sports globally. So we have to find opportunities in districts where we can develop an ecosystem for such sports," Modi said.

"When we speak about preparation for the 2036 Olympics preparation our focus should be that we should prepare athletes who in 2036 can compete in different sports qualify and compete. I announced from the Red Fort (August 15) that we will have a talent hunt programme for ages 5-15 to introduce them to different sports."

Modi said sports is not just about winning medals but its purpose is also nation-building. "When I talk about sports, it isn't just about winning medals, it is a campaign to integrate India's sports power and youth energy to build a Viksit Bharat. I have always said, 'Those who play will blossom'."

Caruana extends lead against Pragg

BENGALURU: Fabiano Caruana extended his lead to 9-3 against R Praggnanandhaa in the Grand Chess Tour Finals title match after surviving five hours and 95 moves to salvage a draw in Game 2. Pragg had winning chances in the bishop endgame but couldn't convert them.

Smith and Cox revive England against Pak

LONDON: Jamie Smith and Jordan Cox both scored fifties as England recovered from a top-order collapse against Pakistan to 248-9 when bad light ended Day 1 at Lord's. Mohammad Abbas took three wickets for four runs in 16 balls, including the prize scalp of England captain Joe Root.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.

EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

hindustantimes htTweets www.hindustantimes.com

Sonal Dinusha's brave resistance denies India a win in second Test

The left-hander scored his third ton of the series as Sri Lanka finished on 429/9 to draw Test

Sanjeev K Samyal
sanjeev.samyalk@htlive.com

MUMBAI: India's bowling limitations were exposed by a fighting batting performance from Sri Lanka's lower order on Day 5 of the second Test at the Sinhalese Sports Club, Colombo, on Thursday.

Playing with five specialist bowlers, India had multiple options but failed to take the last four wickets as Sri Lanka finished on 429/9 declared to take out a memorable draw.

Led by a heroic unbeaten 133 by their rising star, Sonal Dinusha, the home team defied the odds to play out the entire final day and stonewall India's bid for a clean sweep of the two-Test series.

Resuming the day at 229/6, Sri Lanka were effectively 16/6. But, Test cricket rewards resilience, and Dinusha, batting with monk-like concentration, produced a marathon effort, facing 264 balls to turn a lost match into a genuine contest.

The belief for the fightback came during Dinusha's seventh wicket partnership of 112 off 246 balls with Keshara Nuvansa. The duo played out the entire opening session to reach lunch at 329/6 in 104 overs.

Dinusha's biggest test came in the post-lunch session when he lost Keshara immediately on resumption. Keshara was done in by a peach of a delivery from left-arm spinner Manav Suthar, who extracted spin and bounce to induce an outside edge to keeper Dhruv Jurel.

On Saturday, Dinusha turned the tide in the post-lunch session with two quick breakthroughs. Dinusha, however, showed maturity beyond his years and remained unfazed to score his third hundred in two Tests, thwarting Suthar's threat.

The only way to survive on a last day's pitch is to play each ball on merit. That Dinusha could do that was mainly due to the grit shown by Sri Lanka's tailenders.

After Keshara departed, No 9 Prasad Jayasuriya (2 off 28 balls) and Lahiru Kumara (2 off 90 balls) batted it out. They didn't get many runs but by staying at the wicket they allowed Dinusha to play a risk-free game.

Even while batting the No 10 batsman, Kumara, Dinusha didn't have to play desperate shots. He was fine with taking a single of the first ball, following Kumara



Most tons in a 2-Test series

SERIES	PLAYER	VERSUS	INNS	100s	AVG
2022-2023	M Labuschagne (AUS)	v WI	4	3	167.33
2009-2010	H Amla (SA)	v IND	3	3	490.0
2014-2015	Younis Khan (PAK)	v AUS	4	3	156.0
2012-2013	K Sangakkara (SL)	v BAN	4	3	110.25
1996-1997	A de Silva (SL)	v PAK	4	3	216.0
2007-2008	J Kallis (SA)	v PAK	4	3	210.5
2026	S Dinusha (SL)	v IND	4	3	140.0
2023-2024	K Williamson (NZ)	v SA	4	3	134.33
1997-1998	A de Silva (SL)	v IND	3	3	130.67

to face the remainder of the over. It said it all that he had only five fours on way to the 90s (190 balls). His 50 (off 99 balls) had just 2 fours.

Another feature of Dinusha's performance in the series is how he has converted three of his four hundreds into hundreds. He has done that by ensuring he doesn't get bogged down in the nervous 90s. On the final day, he accelerated once he neared the mark, moving into the 90s with two doubles and then hitting a four to move from 93 to 97. On 98 at lunch, he completed his hundred on the first ball after resumption with an on-drive off Mohammed Siraj for a double.

With scores of 100, 84, 103,

133 not out, the 25-year-old aggregated 420 runs and was adjudged as the Player of the Series.

Dinusha's exploits were expected but Keshara exceeded all expectations. Coming into the game, Keshara had an average of only 12 in First-Class cricket. During his 46 runs, he played some impressive strokes.

When India took the new ball, he hit back to back fours off Mohammed Siraj. The first was an upishly driven square of the wicket, but the next ball was a beautiful off drive.

From India's point of view, they did win the series 1-0, but the main goal of bolstering their chances in the WTC final race was laid to waste. India needed

a clean sweep to move above Bangladesh to fourth spot.

The bowlers' inability to break through the lower order on the final day of the two Tests wasted the good work from the first Test win. India remain on fifth spot with 51.52 PCT.

India had the upper hand on the first four days of the contest in Colombo too, but in the final analysis, it amounted to nothing.

It is a dead pitch which truly tests a bowler's quality. On such a track, you need bowlers with the ability to take the surface out of the equation.

Among the Indian bowlers who can do that in tough sub-continent conditions, Jasprit Bumrah, has been rested from

the series for tougher assignments ahead. The bowling attack operating in Sri Lanka were found wanting on the last day, proving that the unit doesn't have the fuel bowl with the same zest for two innings on the trot to back their captain's decision to follow-on.

The scanner will be on the spinners. Manav Suthar finished with figures of 41-7-121-3, debutant Saransh Jain 37-4-98-1 and Ravindra Jadeja 38-3-4-94-3. Among the pacers, much was expected of the experienced Siraj, but his pace was down and had a below par showing of 15-7-26-1. Prashidh Krishna also couldn't repeat his first innings performance for returns 18-3-3-57-1.

SCORECARD	
India 1st Innings 503/9 dec	
Sri Lanka 1st Innings: 290	
Sri Lanka 2nd Innings (overnight) 229/6	
S Dinusha not out	133
N Dickwella live to join	6
K Nuvansa c Jurel b Suthar	46
P Jayasuriya c Jurel b Jadeja	2
L Kumara c Jaiswal b Jadeja	12
A Fernando not out	0
Extras (b 1, lb 8, nb 7, w 3)	25
Total (for wickets, 154 overs)	429
Bowling: Prashidh 16.3-3-57-1, Siraj 15-7-26-1, Suthar 41-7-121-3, Jain 37-4-98-1, Jadeja 38-3-4-94-3, Gill 20-8-8-0, Jaiswal 1-0-9-0, Jurel 2-0-0-0	
Match drawn	



Shubman Gill speaks with the umpire during the fifth day of the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo on Thursday.

Captain Gill left pondering what ifs despite 1-0 win

Rasesh Mandani
rasesh.mandanik@htlive.com

MUMBAI: After their World Test Championship (WTC) final hopes were further dented by the draw in Colombo, Indian captain Shubman Gill might feel the burden that often accompanies introspection.

He wouldn't show it though. "Honestly, nothing," he answered when asked at the post-match presentation if he could have done anything differently on the final day's play. Privately, he might have asked himself, 'what if I had not declared? What if I had not rained to give Sri Lanka another night's sleep on Day 4? What if Mohammed Siraj was the workhorse he has always been and not short of gas, as he appeared to be?'

Before the first ball was bowled in the second Test, Indian head coach Gautam Gambhir was asked another 'what if'.

Of their possible response, if the Sinhalese Sports Club pitch did not deteriorate. His prognosis was that India's bowling strength of five specialist bowlers would do the job.

They didn't prove to be enough. Far from it. It wasn't just Sri Lanka's young batting star Sonal Dinusha, the lower order resisted India for three sessions on the final day. The rain the visitors feared, which influenced their declaration call, never showed up.

"We were anticipating (rain), wanted to take that chance. Had we not taken it and it had rained, you would have asked why no follow-on," Gill told reporters.

To defend his bowlers, Gill said the pitch slowed down considerably taking bowler and bowler out of play.

"I think the wicket got slower. It was not like the ball was not spinning. But the wickets (stumps) were not in play. As a batsman, if you know that the bowlers do not have two modes

of dismissal in play, then it becomes easier to bat. India would still have hoped their bowling unit responded better. Dinusha had already given them a glimpse of how good he was sweeping during his innings of 100 and 84 in the first Test. India's spin trio — Ravindra Jadeja, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain — couldn't force him off his plans in both innings of the Colombo Test match. Sweeps became his default scoring option on the slow pitch as he showed his entire range of broom-work — conventional and reverse.

Gill admitted that their home-work on the profile left-handers' sweeps, of keeping a boundary cover didn't do the job because his defense was "solid" and he played the match situation. "We thought we could get him with fast bowling, but there was no pace in the wicket," Gill said.

Below-par Siraj
Siraj's captaincy decision bent his back right through the series and was fairly successful was Prashidh Krishna. But the experienced Siraj was short of a goal. Gill's explanation was concerning.

"Siraj wasn't injured, but he was coming back after a couple of months. Having played the last Test in June," he said. "Sometimes, it takes time to come back in rhythm. Sometimes you find it as you play."

Gill's captaincy decisions will continue to be closely scrutinised as he leads more in sub-continental conditions. In Sri Lanka, he gave the spinners unusually short spells.

"The idea was to rotate them consistently. Especially on a wicket like this, when a batsman gets set, it's very difficult to get him out. If he's not trying to play shots, he's opted. "So our thinking is you can keep changing the bowlers. Once the batsman is set, if he's keeping playing different kinds of bowlers, it gives us more chance to take wickets."

Deja vu Down Under: Sons of Schwag, Dravid in India U19

HT Correspondent
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Few surnames in Indian cricket arrive carrying as much baggage as legacy. Schwag and Dravid are two of them. Now, nearly a generation later, they are back on the same India roster—not as Virender and Rahul, but as their sons in the under-19 squad.

On Thursday, Aaryavir Sehwa and Anvay Dravid were named in India's under-19 squad for the three-match one-day series against Australia under-19, beginning September 18. Neither is in the multi-day squad, but the selection is significant enough to stir memories of an era when their fathers made Australia one of the great stages of Indian cricket's renaissance.

The search for Dravid and Sehwa together played for India for the last time in the Adelaide Test in January, 2012.

This is the maiden U-19 callup for Aaryavir whose path already contains flashes that make the comparisons inevitable. The teenager made his Delhi U-19 debut in the Vinoo Mankad Trophy in 2024, scoring 49 against Manipal. A year later came the innings that really put his name into circulation—257 for Delhi U-19 against Meghalaya, also in the Coach Behar Trophy.

He stepped into senior cricket with West Delhi Lions in the Delhi Premier League, opening the batting like his father, and wowing audiences with identical square drives and cover drives just a few days back.

Those video clips, naturally, triggered the temptation to look for Virender in Aaryavir—the



Anvay Dravid (L) and Aaryavir Sehwa.

attacking instinct, the willingness to hit through the line, the sense that a ball is there to be struck rather than merely respected. But Aaryavir has built his own evidence and forged his path himself.

A wicketkeeper batter, Aaryavir's journey has been quieter but no less substantial. The younger son of Rahul Dravid has captained Karnataka U-19 and accumulated 220 runs in six matches in the Vinoo Mankad Trophy, averaging 55. His unbeaten 82 against Himachal Pradesh helped Karnataka chase 236, and his performances earned him an India U-19 call-up earlier this year.

Then came a useful reminder that this is a different but equally significant journey. On his India U-19 debut against Sri Lanka in July, Anvay scored 87 from 67 balls, with nine fours and a six, helping India recover from 81/4 with a 145-run partnership with Arjun Rajput.

That they have been picked together for a series against Australia adds even more intrigue and anticipation. For Australia were almost a recurring character in their fathers' greatest stories. Dravid's 180 at Eden Gardens in 2001 formed part of the extraordinary comeback that ended Australia's 16-Test winning streak.

Three years later, in Adelaide, his unbeaten double century helped India secure another famous victory; he finished the 2003-04 Australian series with 619 runs and was named player of the series. Sehwa supplied the fireworks, scoring 195 in two sessions at the MCG in the same tour, finishing with 464 runs. Not one to care for doing what was expected, Sehwa was one of the reasons India became resilient tourists for more than a decade at the turn of the century.

The surnames return together, but in the form of talent whose careers are just beginning. Australia, fittingly, will provide a first chapter at Rajkot which will host all the day-night matches.

UEFA PREPARES CRIMINAL COMPLAINT AGAINST FIFA CHIEF INFANTINO

Agence France-Presse
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

LAUSANNE: European football's governing body UEFA is preparing a criminal complaint against FIFA president Gianni Infantino of "criminal mismanagement" over his new shelved plan to bring private financing into the World Cup, according to a document seen by AFP.

"UEFA is actively considering legal action arising out of and in connection with the plan proposed by FIFA," read the legal document to be filed in a court in Florida in the United States.

The document is a request for permission to gather evidence for a potential criminal complaint in Switzerland, where both UEFA and world football's governing body FIFA are based.

"More specifically, UEFA and other interested parties are preparing to bring criminal claims in Switzerland against Infantino and possibly other FIFA officials and advisors for criminal mismanagement under Article 156 of the Swiss Criminal Code," it continues.

UEFA, whose threat to boycott World Cup is widely seen as having been pivotal in Infantino's humiliating climbdown just days after launching the proposal, laid out a long list of documents they wanted access to pertaining to the background of the FIFA Forward Enterprise (FPE) plan.

India beat Germany to end 5th, best finish since 1974

HT Correspondent
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Indian women's hockey team signed off from the World Cup on a high, defeating world No. 5 Germany 3-1 in the 5th-6th classification playoff in Amstelveen on Thursday.

The result secured the team fifth place, their best finish at the quadrennial showpiece since the inaugural edition in 1974 when they finished fourth.

After a goalless first-half India produced a superb attacking display in the third quarter, scoring twice through Navneet Kaur and once through Ishika to seal a memorable win.

The match began with both teams adopting a cautious approach although Germany enjoyed more possession. Both sides managed to enter the circle but struggled to produce clean shots.

World No. 5 Germany earned their first penalty corner (PC) in the 15th minute after a video referral by India failed to overturn the decision.

Bichu Devi initially kept out the threat while another PC followed when the ball lifted off an Indian stick during the ensuing melee. Germany opted for a variation but a miscommunication saw the ball run out of play.

India created their best opportunity of the second quarter when Deepika Sehrawat found Navneet, who in turn set up Lalremliani. However, her effort went wide. Navneet and Salima Tete combined to test German goalkeeper Finja Starck, who made three successive saves to keep the score level at half-time. The breakthrough finally



India players celebrate after scoring against Germany.

arrived in the 43rd minute. Neha Goyal won possession and quickly released Ishika, who had options on either side but chose to take on the German defence herself. Her run ended with a composed finish that gave India a 1-0 lead.

India doubled their advantage a minute later. A PC was earned and when the first direct attempt from Navneet struck a German rusher, India were awarded another PC. This time, Navneet found the goal with a powerful strike to make it 2-0.

India continued their momentum into the final quarter and struck again in the 47th minute. Salima found Navneet along the baseline and the forward brilliantly manoeuvred around two

defenders before lifting the ball into the net for her second and the team's third.

Germany tried to respond with Lynn Krings narrowly missing her shot. In the 50th minute, Krings eventually pulled one back in the 59th minute. Germany earned one final PC with 12 minutes remaining yet India's defence held firm to complete a memorable 3-1 victory.

India finished the tournament with two wins, three draws and one defeat from six matches.

Their only loss came against defending champions Netherlands while they held higher-ranked China, England and Australia in draws and defeated South Africa 6-1 for their biggest win ever at the World Cup.

44 YEARS AFTER FRANCESCO'S DEBUT, URUGUAY TO RETURN TO KOLKATA

HT Correspondent
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Nearly 44 years after Panama Francesco made his international debut at Eden Gardens, Uruguay will return to the city for a friendly on October 6 completing an unprecedented set of three matches that India will play at home against teams from the 2026 World Cup.

"La Celeste's arrival in Kolkata adds another major fixture to an unprecedented run of international football for Indian fans, with three World Cup-playing nations — Panama, Brazil and Diego Forlan — who replaced Maycel dos Santos in the FIFA window," AIFF said in a media release on Thursday.

India will also travel to 2026 World Cup final host New Zealand for two friendlies making this a year like no other for the men's national team.

The first match will be against Panama in Bengaluru on Sept 26. That match will help head coach Khalid Jamil get ready for the game against Brazil in Kolkata on Oct 3. Jamil is likely to hold a preparatory camp in Bengaluru from the middle of September.

Uruguay are managed by 2010 World Cup Golden Ball winner Diego Forlan who replaced Maycel dos Santos after the World Cup. Forlan represented Mumbai City FC in the Indian Super League in 2016.

The first Nehru Cup in 1982, Francesco, 20, scored on debut in the 1-0 win against Yugoslavia B. He scored a goal in the 3-2 victory over an Italy Olympic side. India lost 1-3 to Uruguay who beat China 2-0 in the final.